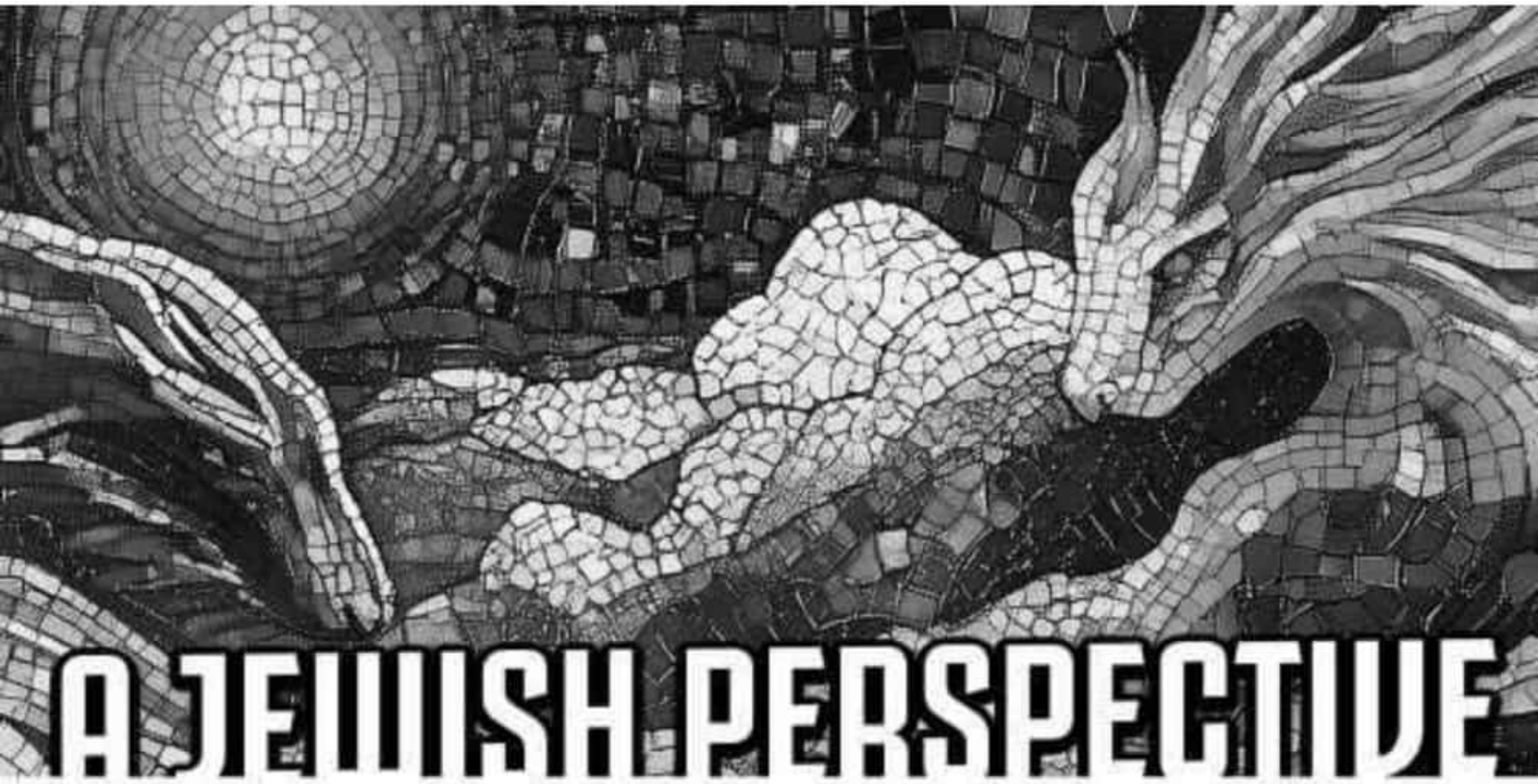
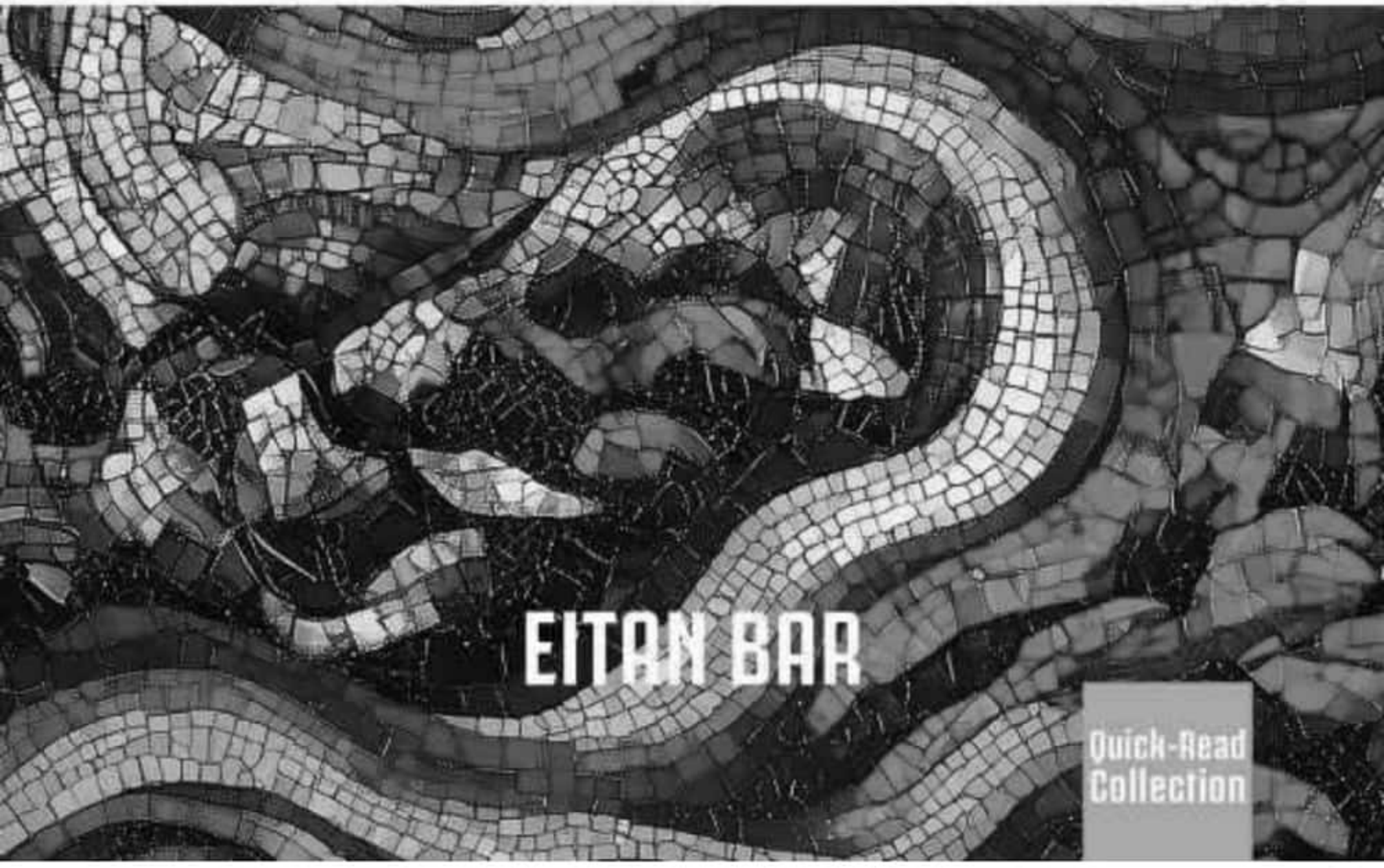


REVELATION



Revelation

A Jewish Perspective

Eitan Bar

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Contents

Preface

1. Introduction

2. Revelation: A Jewish Book

3. How Should Apocalyptic Literature Be Read?

4. The Book of Daniel: The Backbone of Revelation

The Bible Project

5. Revelation 1-3: The Seven Churches

6. Revelation 4-5: The Heavenly Throne Room and First Judgment

7. Revelation 6-7: The Lord's Slain Servants

8. Revelation 8-11: Judgment, Temple, and Two Witnesses

9. Revelation 12: The Dragon, the Woman, and Her Child

10. Revelation 13: The Two Beasts

11. Revelation 14-16: Judgment and Armageddon

12. Revelation 17-20: The Fall of Babylon

13. Revelation 21-22: The New Heaven and Earth

14. A Speculative Perspective on Future Events

15. Conclusion: The Lamb Wins — So Choose Your Side

A Small Request

Endnotes

Preface

The book will be divided into two main parts. The first part will cover aspects such as genre, context, and authorship, while the second part will delve into the text of the Book of Revelation.

This work is not designed to be an exhaustive, verse-by-verse commentary that analyzes every detail; instead, it aims to provide a broad overview of key themes and patterns found in Revelation. Rather than getting bogged down in specifics, it offers a panoramic, bird's-eye view that aids readers in understanding the larger narrative, recurring symbols, and profound messages intricately woven into the text.

Furthermore, if you never before had the chance, I recommend that you read the Book of Revelation.

Introduction

While some have questioned whether the John of Revelation was the same person who authored the Gospel of John and the Epistles of John (due to differences in writing style and theological emphasis), the traditional view remains that the Apostle John—one of the twelve disciples of Jesus—wrote Revelation.

Yochanan (John)

John's Hebrew name—*Yochanan*—means "God is gracious" or "Yahweh has shown favor."

Yochanan, the son of Zebedee, was born into a deeply Jewish world, shaped by the rhythms, traditions, and scriptures of his Jewish people. He was raised in a Jewish Galilean fishing family, likely in Bethsaida or Capernaum, two towns heavily influenced by Jewish culture yet also exposed to Greco-Roman trade and ideas. His upbringing would have been steeped in Torah (the first five books of the Bible) studies, the prophetic writings, and the expectation that Israel's God would act decisively in history. From an early age, Yochanan would have learned Hebrew Scriptures, participated in synagogue worship, and observed the sacred festivals that bound the Jewish people together in identity and faith.

In the first century, Jewish boys typically began formal Torah education no later than 5 years old, as reflected in later Rabbinic tradition.[1] However, preparation and informal exposure to Jewish teachings, prayers, and customs began at 3, with Jewish parents instilling foundational knowledge.

Like many young Jewish boys of his time, Yochanan's education likely began with memorization of the *SHEMA*—Israel's central confession of faith—and expanded to include the Torah, psalms, the history of Israel, and the teachings of the prophets. This foundation in Jewish thought is evident throughout his writings, particularly in his Gospel and the Book of Revelation, both of which brim with Old Testament allusions and echoes of well-known Jewish apocalyptic imagery.

As a young man, Yochanan, whom from now on we'll call 'John', was also part of the thriving fishing trade on the Sea of Galilee, working alongside his brother James and their father. This was no small, isolated occupation but a trade deeply connected to Jewish economic life. Fishing was regulated by Jewish purity laws and was part of the broader sustenance system of Galilee, which had its own unique Jewish identity, distinct from the more urbanized Judea. The presence of Roman occupation over Jews in the region was a constant reminder of Israel's subjugation, fueling the hope for divine intervention and the restoration of Israel's kingdom.

It was in this world of Jewish expectation that John encountered Rabbi Yeshua (Jesus).[2] Along with his brother James, he was first a disciple of John the Baptist, a fiery prophet calling the nation of Israel to repentance in anticipation of God's coming reign. John's decision to follow Jesus was not a departure from his Jewish faith, but a deepening of it. Jesus, after all, was not introducing a new and foreign religion, but was a Jewish rabbi proclaiming the fulfillment of Israel's scriptures, the realization of its ancient hopes. In that respect, it could be said that John the Apostle was the last of Israel's prophets.

John's writings reflect this immersion in Jewish thought. His Gospel opens with a profound allusion to Genesis 1:1—*"**In the beginning** was the Word"* (John 1:1)—placing Jesus within the very fabric of Israel's creation story. His visions in Revelation draw heavily from the Hebrew prophets, including Daniel, Ezekiel, and Isaiah, transforming their imagery to reveal Jesus as the culmination of God's promises. His depiction of Jesus as a Lamb carries unmistakable Jewish and Passover connotations, reinforcing the continuity between Jewish sacrificial traditions and Jesus' redemptive work, often overlooked by Western Christians.[3]

Even as the message of Jesus spread beyond Israel to the Gentile world, John remained a bridge between Judaism and the emerging Christian faith. His deep familiarity with the Old Testament shaped his theological reflections, ensuring that

Christianity, in its earliest form, remained rooted in the history, theology, tradition, and identity of the Jewish people.

To understand John is to recognize him not as a member of a founding committee of a new religion but as a Jewish man whose worldview was entirely shaped by the scriptures and traditions of his ancestors. His transformation—from fisherman to disciple, from witness to apostle, from exile to visionary—was not a break from Judaism but its fulfillment in the person of Jesus, his Rabbi and the Jewish Messiah he had come to believe in with unwavering conviction.

To put it differently, a modern-day reader cannot completely grasp John's writings —particularly Revelation—without a solid understanding of the Hebrew Scriptures and the Jewish apocalyptic genre.

Around the age of 90, John was exiled to Patmos, a small island in the Aegean Sea, during the reign of Emperor Domitian (81–96 AD), likely around 95 AD (Revelation 1:9), where he wrote Revelation. The Romans often used islands like Patmos to exile political prisoners, particularly those perceived as threats to the empire. Since Domitian's reign saw increased persecution of Christians, it is possible that other Jewish and non-Jewish believers were also exiled there alongside John.

The Literary Style of Revelation

The apocalyptic genre, which was deeply embedded in second-temple Jewish thought and literature, is largely absent from today's Western world, especially in its original form. Modern Western literature tends to favor realism, rationalism, and linear storytelling, whereas Jewish apocalyptic writing was highly symbolic, nonlinear (cyclical), and heavily steeped in visions and cryptic imagery depicting cosmic battles between good and evil.

Authors of ancient Jewish apocalyptic literature, including books like Daniel, Enoch, 2 Esdras, 2 Baruch, and Revelation, wrote during times of persecution and oppression, often offering hope to the faithful by revealing divine intervention in history.

Apocalyptic literature employs fantastical creatures, numerology, celestial battles, military imagery, and symbolic divine judgment to illustrate the cosmic struggle between good and evil: God's kingdom and the oppressive forces of the world. The apocalyptic genre thrived in Second Temple Judaism but mostly disappeared as

Western thought moved away from Judaism toward Greek philosophy and scientific reasoning.

This could explain why many in the West approach apocalyptic literature like a textbook—attempting to piece together random verses from across the Bible in hopes of unlocking a precise end-times timeline. For instance, how the *Left Behind* series interprets Revelation's symbolism literally rather than engaging with its Jewish symbolic structure. This view, however, is a fundamental misunderstanding of the Jewish apocalyptic genre, which was never intended to serve as a manual for forecasting the future like a crystal ball.

Today, while science fiction, dystopian literature, and political allegories sometimes borrow some elements of apocalyptic themes (e.g., The Hunger Games), they lack the distinct Jewish theological framework that shaped biblical apocalypticism. Instead of seeing history through the lens of divine sovereignty, prophetic fulfillment, and messianic expectation, modern Western sci-fi narratives focus more on secular themes of survival, technological collapse, or social upheaval.

Interpreting Revelation's symbolism and imagery literally, rather than through its Jewish symbolic structure, risks missing the original intention and context of the text. Jewish apocalyptic literature was not designed as a precise prediction of future events but as a symbolic and theological message, offering hope to the faithful in times of oppression, tribulation and persecution. It used vivid imagery to convey deeper spiritual truths about God's sovereignty and the ultimate triumph of His kingdom. When Revelation is reduced to a rigid linear end-times timeline, its historical and literary context is lost, distorting its meaning and shifting the focus from perseverance and divine justice to speculation and, often, fear-based doctrine.

In short, true Jewish apocalyptic writing was a product of its time, culture, and theological worldview and it is a genre largely missing from modern writing.

This is one reason the Book of Revelation is one of the most mysterious and debated texts in the entire Bible. Its vivid imagery, strange creatures, cosmic battles, and startling visions have led to countless interpretations. To many in the West, Revelation is primarily a roadmap to the future, a manual of literal prediction of the future, complete with a seven-year tribulation, a supernatural rapture, an Antichrist, and a final military battle of Armageddon. This reading of the book, however, largely disregards its historical setting and the apocalyptic genre.

Revelation: A Jewish Book

Revelation belongs to a well-established genre of Jewish apocalyptic literature, which emerged in the centuries before and continued after the time of Jesus. Jewish apocalyptic writings—including extrabiblical writings such as 1 Enoch, 2 Esdras, and the War Scroll from the Dead Sea Scrolls—were written in times of crisis, offering divine hope and a peek into history's final outcome. These texts never meant to function as literal blueprints of future events but as symbolic visions meant to encourage the faithful during oppression. Revelation follows this pattern exactly.

John, the Jewish author of Revelation, addressed his message to seven churches in Asia Minor—predominantly Gentile communities. Given this, it seems puzzling that his work is saturated with Jewish imagery, drawing extensively from the Hebrew Bible. Why would John fill his apocalyptic vision with symbols from a tradition many of his readers might not have been fully familiar with? The answer lies in understanding the nature of early Christianity, the role of Jewish apocalyptic literature, and the way biblical prophecy functions.

Why Use Jewish Symbols if His Audience Was Largely Gentile?

The answer lies in the very nature of early Christianity. Most Christians today perceive Christianity as a predominantly Gentile religion, entirely detached from Judaism. However, in its earliest form, Christianity was not a separate faith but rather a

movement, sect or denomination within Judaism, deeply rooted in Jewish beliefs, scriptures, and traditions. Christianity only became an official religion in the 4th century. For at least the first two centuries, followers of Jesus — including both Jewish and Gentile converts (God-Fearers) — viewed themselves as part of Israel's covenant community, a Jewish-like denomination that considered Jesus as the Jewish fulfillment of the Jewish messianic expectations rather than the founder of some new religion. It was only through much later historical developments, theological disputes, and social pressures that Christianity gradually diverged from its Jewish foundations and became a distinct, often very antisemitic religion.

This is partly due to the early, intentional separation of Christianity from its Jewish roots, especially by Emperor Constantine (4th century), who worked to create a "Jewish-free" religion—removing Jewish leaders and theologians from important roles within the church, which had lasting effects on Christian-Jewish relations and on Christian interpretation of the Bible.

Thus, even though the Seven Churches of Revelation were primarily composed of Gentile God-Fearers, their faith was rooted in Jewish thought.

When the Church Was Still Jewish

In the first-century churches of Asia Minor, Jewish believers or "Messianic Jews" (not to be mistaken for the modern movement bearing the same name[4]) played a significant role alongside Gentile converts, shaping the early Christian communities. For instance, the apostle Paul was the *"apostle to the Gentiles"* (Romans 11:13), yet in his missionary journeys he consistently began preaching in Jewish synagogues, as seen in Ephesus, where he reasoned with the Jews before turning to Gentiles (e.g., Acts 18:19-21, 19:8-10). Similarly, in Galatia, Jewish and Gentile believers coexisted, though tensions arose over Jewish customs, prompting Paul's rebuke of Peter for withdrawing from Gentile fellowship (Galatians 2:14). In Colossae, warnings against Jewish legalism (Colossians 2:16-17) imply a mixed congregation, while Paul's reminder that in Christ there is no distinction between Jew and Greek (Colossians 3:11) underscores the unity he sought to cultivate between the Jewish and gentiles believers.

The churches of Revelation, including those in Smyrna and Philadelphia, also encountered Jewish-Christian interactions. These communities, whether in Pergamum, Thyatira, or Laodicea, reflected the broader pattern of early Christian gatherings, where Jewish and Gentile believers worshiped together, sometimes in harmony and other times in tension.

Furthermore, the early Jewish followers of Jesus saw themselves as part of Israel's story, not as founders of a new, non-existing religion. Thus, in John's day, the "Christian" church was still very much Jewish in identity, practice, and worldview. Even the non-Jewish "God-Fearers" considered themselves part of Israel's narrative.

The God-Fearers

The **God-fearers** (e.g., Acts 10:1-2, 13:16, 13:26, 16:14, 17:4, 18:7) were Gentiles in the Second Temple period who worshiped the God of Israel and followed many aspects of Jewish religious practices but were not fully converted to Judaism. They attended Jewish synagogues, studied Jewish texts and the Hebrew Scriptures, observed some Jewish customs (such as keeping the Sabbath and dietary laws), and followed Jewish ethical teachings.

Pre-Christ, many God-fearers were likely introduced to Judaism through their Jewish friends, neighbors, or business associates. Since they attended synagogues and were already familiar with the Hebrew Scriptures, they were natural candidates for early Christian evangelism and, most likely, the main target-audience of Paul's mission trips.

The transition of God-fearers to Christianity is somewhat like a modern Catholic "converting" to a Protestant denomination (or vice versa). It's simply a shift of theological perspectives within the same general religious framework. The God-fearers simply transitioned from one Jewish denomination to another.

When Paul and other apostles preached in synagogues, they often found a mixed audience of Jews and God-fearing Gentiles (Acts 13:16, 17:4). These Gentiles were already drawn to monotheism and Jewish ethics, making them very open to the message of Jesus as the Jewish Messiah without the barrier of circumcision and full Torah observance.

The God-fearers were among the Gentile believers addressed in Acts 15:29 when the Jerusalem Council decided that Gentiles who followed Jesus did not need to fully convert to Judaism by undergoing circumcision or keeping the entire Torah. Instead, they were only required to abstain from food sacrificed to idols, blood, meat from strangled animals, and sexual immorality.[5] This dynamic helps explain why many of Paul's early converts came from this group—they were already very familiar with Jewish beliefs and thus more receptive to the gospel.

Thus, the first-century churches of Asia Minor were deeply rooted in a Jewish worldview and theology. Their understanding of Scripture, time, and symbolism was shaped by the Hebrew Bible and Second Temple Jewish thought. As a result, they would have easily grasped John's use of well-known Jewish apocalyptic symbols in the Book of Revelation. What might seem cryptic or bizarre to modern readers would have been familiar and meaningful to them, rich with layers of symbolic and theological depth.

The Biblical Concept of Time

It is essential to briefly address the role and understanding of time in biblical times because John's use of rich Old Testament symbolism and the distinct genre of Jewish apocalyptic style of writing suggests a message meant to transcend time, conveying deep theological truths that are cyclical rather than being a straightforward forecast of what is to come.

While a symbolic interpretation doesn't exclude the reality of future events (such as the final victory of Christ and the New Jerusalem), the emphasis is on symbols that convey timeless truths or recurring patterns, fitting the Jewish understanding of time as being cyclical rather than purely linear.

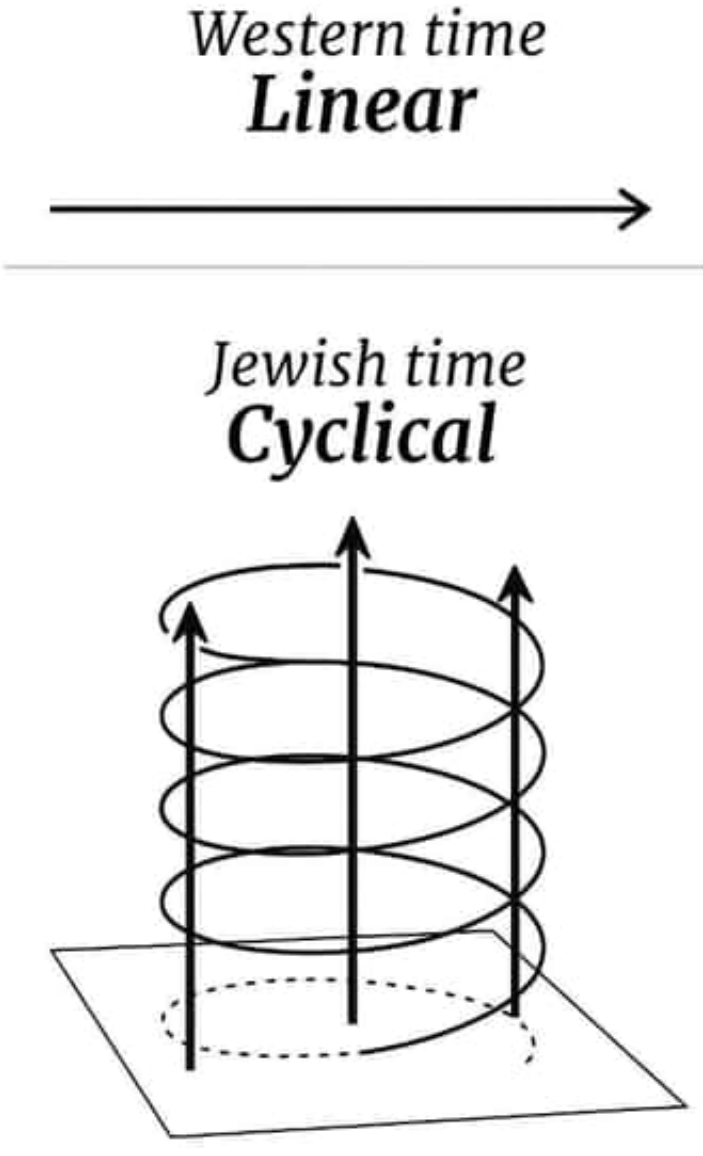
While Western thought tends to view time as a straight line — past, present, future, with a clear beginning and end — the biblical Jewish mindset sees time as a series of cycles, rhythms, and recurring patterns that move history forward like a spiral, not a line.

This can be seen in the weekly rhythm of Shabbat, the annual cycle of feasts and festivals, and in prophetic literature where past events echo into the future. Events

repeat — not identically, but thematically — with each cycle deepening in meaning and pointing toward ultimate fulfillment.

Redemption, exile, return, judgment, and renewal are themes that happen again and again throughout Scripture. The story of Israel is not a onetime plotline, but a repeated pattern woven into human history — and ultimately, the story of the Messiah follows that same pattern: death, burial, resurrection — not just once, but mirrored in creation, in nations, in individuals.

This cyclical understanding is crucial when reading apocalyptic or prophetic texts like Revelation because these texts are rarely linear timelines but symbolic portrayals of repeated patterns — cycles of human failure, divine intervention, and ultimate restoration.



Revelation Cannot Be Understood Without the Hebrew Scriptures

To understand the Jewishness of Revelation, one must first consider its sources. The book is not an isolated vision but part of a long tradition of Jewish apocalyptic literature that stretches across the Hebrew Scriptures. John does not invent a new prophetic language; he inherits and adapts a system of Jewish symbols and imagery deeply embedded in Jewish tradition. His visions are saturated with references to the prophets, including Isaiah, Ezekiel, Daniel, and Zechariah, each of whom contributed essential elements to the apocalyptic framework that Revelation employs.

Let's consider a few quick examples…

Daniel

Take, for example, the frightening vision of the beast rising from the sea in Revelation 13. This image does not emerge in a vacuum but is a direct reference to the monstrous beasts of **Daniel 7**, which represent oppressive empires that rise but then fall under God's sovereign control. Daniel's vision describes four beasts, each symbolizing a different oppressive kingdom, culminating in a final, terrifying entity that is crushed by the arrival of God's kingdom.

By drawing upon this imagery, John signals to his readers that the power he describes—the beast of his own era—is part of the same recurring pattern of imperial domination and divine justice. The reference also reassures believers that, just as Daniel's vision ends with God's triumph, so too will their own struggle.

Isaiah

Similarly, the depiction of the new heaven and new earth in Revelation 21 is an unmistakable allusion to **Isaiah 65:17**, where God declares, *"See, I will create new heavens and a new earth. The former things will not be remembered, nor will they come to mind."* In Isaiah, this promise is given as a vision of hope for a restored Israel, a world where suffering and death will be eradicated. John continues this vision of a cosmic renewal, no longer limited to Israel but encompassing all creation. His use of Isaiah's imagery reinforces the idea that God's redemptive plan is not something new but the culmination of promises made long ago.

Ezekiel

Another such example appears in the measuring of the temple in Revelation 11. This scene parallels **Ezekiel's** vision in chapters 40–48, where an angel meticulously measures the dimensions of a restored temple. In Ezekiel, this act represents

God's plan to reestablish His dwelling place among His people, symbolizing future restoration and divine presence. When John echoes this imagery, he is making a theological statement about the true temple—not merely a physical structure, but the people of God themselves. In a world where the physical temple in Jerusalem had been destroyed by Rome, John's vision reinterprets Ezekiel's vision symbolically, pointing to a deeper, spiritual reality.

By grounding his visions in these prophetic traditions, John does not merely borrow language; he weaves himself into the ongoing narrative of God's interaction with His people. His message is not about a wholly new revelation but about the fulfillment and transformation of ancient prophetic revelations. This approach would have resonated deeply with Jewish readers or those familiar with the Hebrew Scriptures, as they would recognize the allusions and understand the implications.

Revelation: The Final Book in the Series

Understanding these intertextual connections helps clarify that Revelation is not meant to be read in isolation. It is part of a much broader apocalyptical and theological framework—one that continually points back to the faithfulness of God in history.

While Revelation is part of—and the last book of—the larger collection of books known as the Bible, it also belongs to a distinct series: Jewish apocalyptic literature.

By using the same language as Daniel, Isaiah, Ezekiel, Zechariah and other extrabiblical apocalyptical books, John ensures that his audience sees Revelation not as an unpredictable new prophecy, but as the inevitable continuation and culmination of God's already established plan for His people. This not only strengthens the credibility of his vision but also roots it firmly in the expectation of divine justice that had sustained the people of Israel for centuries.

The Jewishness of Revelation is thus not incidental but foundational. The book stands as the final, climactic chapter of the apocalyptic tradition, a vision that does not discard the past but brings it to its intended fulfillment. It is only by grasping the symbols and metaphors already in use for centuries that one can fully appreciate the depth and meaning of John's vision, seeing it as the grand culmination of a story that had been unfolding for generations.

Conclusion

Revelation's extensive use of Jewish symbolism, even for predominantly Gentile communities, reflects the deep Jewish roots and worldview of early Christianity itself. John's audience, familiar with Jewish scriptures and traditions through their interaction with Jewish believers and God-fearing Gentiles, would have recognized his imagery not as obscure, but as deeply familiar. By tapping into a rich heritage of prophetic symbolism, John reassured his readers of God's faithfulness, showing that their current struggles fit into a timeless pattern of divine promise and ultimate victory, which we will later expand upon.

How Should Apocalyptic Literature Be Read?

The Bible is a Hebrew and Jewish masterpiece. As such, its mindset, expression, and communication style are deeply metaphorical, using vivid imagery, symbolic language, and layered meanings to convey timeless truths. Biblical Hebrew, for instance, has a relatively limited vocabulary compared to many modern languages. This constraint often results in the frequent use of metaphors, symbols, and figures of speech by Jewish prophets, rabbis and authors, to express complex ideas, emotions, and spiritual realities. As a result, interpreting biblical thought demands an understanding of cultural, historical, and literary context—often more so than modern languages, which tend to be more direct and explicit.

Rooted in a worldview where the physical and spiritual are deeply interconnected, Jewish apocalyptic literature is highly abstract, forcing nuanced interpretations that go beyond the literal. It makes apocalyptic literature—like the Book of Revelation—especially powerful for conveying deep spiritual truths. At the same time, it poses significant interpretive challenges, particularly for the average Western mindset, which tends to favor a straightforward, linear, analytical thinking and may be less familiar with the symbolic richness of the apocalyptic genre.

For instance, the modern mind has grown accustomed to warnings being literal and straightforward—like highway signs or stickers on electronics and instruction manuals. Biblical prophecy, apocalyptic literature, and Jewish writings, however, communicate warnings differently, often through rich symbols and metaphors. Revelation is filled with such imagery, but prime examples can also be found in Jesus' teachings, where warnings are frequently expressed metaphorically—such as the "narrow gate" leading to life (Matthew 7:13-14), "wolves disguised

as sheep" (Matthew 7:15), "unquenchable fire" (Matthew 3:12), “gnashing of teeth” (Matthew 8:12), a "house built upon sand" (Matthew 7:26-27) or the suggestion to "pluck out your eye" (Matthew 18:9).

John, like his rabbi Jesus, used highly figurative language. Apocalyptic literature, like the Book of Revelation, amplifies this literary style to the maximum.

Symbolism vs. Literalism: A Modern Misreading

The Bible—especially the apocalyptic texts—is filled with vivid, imaginative, symbolic imagery that would sound utterly absurd if taken literally. In **Daniel** 7:3-7, four great beasts emerge from the sea—one like a lion with eagle’s wings, another like a bear devouring flesh, a leopard with four heads and wings, and a final beast with iron teeth and ten horns. No Jewish reader expected to see these creatures stomping through Jerusalem; rather, they represent kingdoms and rulers. Similarly, **Zechariah** 5:1-2 describes a massive flying scroll, thirty feet long, soaring through the air as a curse upon the land. **Ezekiel** 1:5-14 paints an even wilder picture of heavenly beings with four faces—human, lion, ox, and eagle—darting around like flashes of lightning on wheels covered in eyes.

Jewish apocalyptic literature outside the Bible followed the same pattern. In 1 Enoch, nations and rulers are depicted as animals—rams, sheep, and eagles locked in cosmic struggle. 4 Ezra features a monstrous, many-winged eagle ruling the world, its heads speaking with different voices. These texts use highly imaginative visions to communicate deep spiritual and historical truths, a method Revelation later employed as well.

Figurative Language in Everyday Speech

While apocalyptic language relies heavily on symbolism and metaphor, its vivid, poetic imagery isn't completely foreign to the modern mind. Consider the following paragraph:

My brain is **fried** after that meeting, which was a complete **trainwreck**, and now I'm **drowning** in work trying to fix the mess. This project feels like a **ticking time bomb** ready to **explode**, and dealing with someone who has a **heart of stone** only makes things worse. Meanwhile, she's constantly **fishing** for compliments, and though that exam was a **piece of cake**, I've **hit a wall** in my training. To top it off, I have to watch out for him—he's a **snake in the grass**—but at least she's the **light of my life**, keeping me going through it all.

Each of these sentences contains metaphorical or symbolic elements that your brain instinctively interprets as such. Imagine, however, someone two thousand years from now reading it literally. Apocalyptic language amplifies this style, incorporating fantastical imagery, poetic expression, and symbolic depth while using far less literal language. A closer approximation of apocalyptic expression might sound like the following:

The bridge of trust lay shattered, stones reduced to dust by neglect. Doubt obscured his vision, leaving dreams drifting away like ships abandoned at sea. She had nurtured a garden with seeds of kindness, waiting patiently for his love to bloom. But storms of indifference raged within him, tearing hope from the roots. From shadows emerged another, offering warmth where he had only given coldness, quietly stealing her heart away. In the dim sky above, regret circled like a creature with fiery wings, darkening the glow of memories that flickered like fading lamp-stands. Time flowed onward, carrying whispers of lost chances in scrolls of silent witnesses. His heart became a locked door, rusted shut by remorse, while loneliness grazed upon the ashes of his pride. Still, in the quiet halls of solitude, her voice lingered—a gentle echo of love now forever beyond his reach.

This paragraph, while vague and confusing at first, is rich in symbolism, painting a vivid picture of a broken relationship while avoiding direct, literal language—much like the apocalyptic genre.

Why Use "Confusing" Language Instead of Clear, Literal, Straightforward Language?

I often come across an argument made by fundamentalists that goes something like this:

"God wants people to understand His plan, so the Bible should be read literally, in a plain and straightforward manner, taking the text at face value."

For instance, in his *Introduction to the Book of Revelation*, renowned Baptist preacher Tom Wallace argues:

> God had no motivation or need to attempt any sort of codification or camouflage for the written word. So this means we are to read the Bible literally...God wrote what he meant and He meant what He wrote. The same goes for all the books of prophecy in the Bible.[6]

While there are hermeneutical ways to respond to this argument, I've addressed those in another book focused on biblical interpretation.[7] Here, I will offer a theological argument instead—recognizing Satan's failure to understand prophetic/apocalyptic language.

Confusing The Devil

Biblical prophecy, veiled in symbolic language, is often accompanied by the statement that only those with spiritual eyes and ears can truly perceive its codified meaning. This theme runs through both the Old and New Testaments (Isaiah 6:9–10, Ezekiel 12:2, Matthew 13:13–15, 1 Corinthians 2:14). This is also true in Revelation (2:7,

2:11, 2:17), where spiritual discernment is emphasized as required to understanding prophecy. Prophecy is not just about reading the words—it's about having a certain kind of spiritual sensitivity, something the Devil lacks.

Evil's ability to understand prophetic imagery appears to be severely limited, as demonstrated by his failure to recognize that the Messiah's death was not a defeat, but the very means of redemption. The prophets foretold of a "suffering servant" who would be *"led like a lamb to the slaughter"* but later *"will see the light of life"* (Isaiah 53:7, 11), yet Satan and his subjects obviously failed to interpret the symbolism of these prophecies correctly.

It seems that Satan's greatest weakness wasn't a lack of power—but a lack of wisdom. He was brilliant but blind. Like an empathy-lacking narcissist obsessed with control, hierarchy, and appearances, he may have been completely incapable of grasping the symbolic, poetic, metaphoric, and allegorical ways of God. This could also explain, at least in part, why *"Jesus spoke...in parables; he did not say anything to them without using a parable."* (Matthew 13:34)

I find that many Western pastors and theologians are masters of logic yet imprisoned by literalism — excellent lawyers brilliant in structure and argument, but often unable to perceive anything beyond the surface. They struggle to grasp the layered, symbolic, and mystical dimensions of Scripture that were second nature to ancient Jewish thought. In their effort to be precise, they sometimes flatten the text, missing the underlying message.

In that sense, the great prosecutor and accuser, Satan, who couldn't comprehend that the suffering servant would conquer death through dying Himself, is also a prisoner of literalism. He could manipulate facts and laws, but the mystery of divine love—sacrificial love—remained hidden from him, precisely because it was veiled in symbols, metaphors, and prophetic apocalyptic language.

In that sense, Satan was the ultimate literalist—and it was this very blindness that led to his downfall. Ironically, many people today fall into the same trap, reading metaphors and symbolism literally and missing the deeper, redemptive beauty of God's ways.

Had the plan of redemption been laid out in a purely literal, straightforward, and obvious language, Satan would have understood it—and sought to prevent it rather than facilitate it. Instead, he played right into God's hands. He influenced Judas

to betray Jesus (Luke 22:3) and pushed the rulers to demand His crucifixion (1 Corinthians 2:8), thinking he was orchestrating the Messiah's downfall:

> *None of the rulers of this age understood it, for if they had, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory.*
>
> 1 Corinthians 2:8

In reality, by crucifying Jesus, evil was ensuring its own defeat.

This demonstrates why God often communicates through symbols, metaphors, images, and visions—not to confuse, but to conceal truth from those who would misuse it while revealing it to those with *"eyes to see"* (Matthew 13:11-13) and *"wisdom to understand"* (Revelation 13:18).

The symbolic nature of prophecy acts as a divine filter, allowing God's plan to unfold without interference from those who oppose Him, while rewarding the faithful with deeper understanding.

Concealing Truth

This sophistication isn't reserved for the Bible alone. There's a reason smart politicians often use symbolic and metaphorical language—if they don't want their words to be taken out of context, if they wish to conceal the truth, or if they don't want to be held accountable for their words later.

Or imagine someone whose entire life's work was forcibly taken from them. Unable to speak openly, whether out of fear or due to a signed non-disclosure agreement, they turn to apocalyptic language to express themselves:

> In days long past, I birthed a fragile, innocent infant, a vision nurtured with love and care. Over time, the child grew, gaining strength and purpose. But in a moment of shadow, a fearless beast cloaked in doctrines foreign to the child's essence seized the child from my arms. The beast twisted its foundations, claiming it as its

own, leaving it a hollow vessel, disconnected from its true roots. The child, once vibrant with life and promise, now wanders in a foreign land, its soul torn between the original light and the dark forces that reshaped it into a fortune-making forge.

Furthermore, to ensure that John could effectively deliver his letter to the churches via the Roman authorities without causing offense, employing apocalyptic language proved to be beneficial.

A Language Above All Languages

The use of metaphorical and figurative language, such as in parables, poems, and apocalyptic literature, testifies to a sophisticated method of communication designed not to convey manual-like dry facts but to engage our God-given imagination, provoke deeper spiritual reflection, and invite active interpretation. Such language draws listeners and readers into a participatory experience (Psalm 1:2, Joshua 1:8), requiring spiritual sensitivity, discernment, and openness to multi-layered meanings. Rather than oversimplifying ideas into easily digestible and simplistic formulas, allegorical communication recognizes the complexity of spiritual realities and testifies to the richness of the Divine mind behind it.

Symbolic language is often seen as superior to literal expression because it communicates on multiple levels at once, enriching thought and deepening emotional impact. Like poetry or visual art, it invites contemplation and allows for nuanced interpretation. Metaphors and symbols can transcend cultural and historical boundaries in ways that literal language often cannot. While literal descriptions may become outdated because the meaning of words change over time, symbolic images —such as a shepherd caring for his sheep (Psalm 23:1)—retain their relevance across cultures and generations.

Symbolic language is especially effective in expressing abstract, spiritual, or deeply emotional truths, like love, justice, and compassion, which defy precise literal definition, especially in biblical times. Metaphors like *"Smoke rose from his nostrils; consuming fire came from his mouth"* (Psalms 18:8) reach beyond intellectual

understanding and resonate with emotions and personal experience, often speaking more powerfully to the heart than to the mind. Therefore, the Jewish prophets and rabbis, including Jesus, more often than not, speak in parables (Matthew 13:34).

Moreover, symbols naturally adapt to diverse contexts, offering layers of meaning that individuals can apply to their own circumstances, which makes them enduring and deeply human. This is especially true of the Book of Revelation.

Understanding this linguistic device helps readers appreciate how Revelation and similar apocalyptic texts communicate their messages, not through straightforward, literal narration, but the Jewish way[8]—through layers of symbolic meaning embedded in dramatic and often surreal imagery.

This is precisely why, as a Jew, I find it somewhat frustrating to see so many Christians in the West insist on reading Revelation *as literally as possible*.

For instance, one of the most popular websites among Christians in America is "Got Questions,"[9] a fundamentalist website that frequently promotes Baptist and Calvinistic teachings. Nevertheless, in its article titled ***"How Can I Understand the Book of Revelation?"*** it states:

> **The key to understanding the book of Revelation is to interpret it as literally as possible**—it says what it means and means what it says.
>
> Got Questions Website

Likewise, the author of *Left Behind*, Tim LaHaye, states in the introduction of his book on Revelation that one should *"take every word at its primary, ordinary, usual, **literal** meaning."*[10]

Challenge accepted! Now let the good times roll…

Interpreting the Book of Revelation *"As Literally as Possible"*

While there are hundreds if not thousands of metaphors and symbolic depictions

in the book of Revelation, we'll explore only a few examples to demonstrate why reading Revelation "as literally as possible" is not just impractical, but resulting in an utterly bizarre and nonsensical narrative that defies logic, science, and even basic coherence. If taken at face value, the book turns into a surreal nightmare where physics is meaningless, creatures are grotesque beyond belief, and divine justice plays out like a chaotic fantasy novel.

Consider just how absurd this would be:

- In **Revelation 3:12**, God promises to "make a pillar in the temple" those who kept faithful. Imagine standing in heaven one day, only to find yourself transformed into a giant marble column, forever stuck in place while angels dust you off for eternity. Do you get to pick your architectural style? Corinthian, Ionic, or maybe something more modern?

- In **Revelation 8:12**, "a third of the sun was struck," along with the moon and stars, as if celestial bodies could be neatly divided like slices of a pie without obliterating the entire solar system. How exactly does a third of the sun get destroyed while the rest continues shining?

- **Revelation 8:13** describes an eagle flying in midair, screaming with a loud voice, "Woe! Woe! Woe to the inhabitants of the earth." A literal reading would have us believe that, instead of a prophet or angel, God chose to deliver a cosmic message through a bird with a megaphone.

– The locusts in **Revelation 9:7-8** supposedly have human faces, golden crowns, women's hair, lion's teeth, and scorpion-like stingers. If taken literally, these creatures would be an absolute nightmare of evolutionary confusion—part insect, part human, part mammal, part reptile. The horror film industry could only dream of inventing something this grotesque.

– **Revelation 9:17-19** introduces horses with tails that are actually snakes, because, why not? Are these horses or mutant serpentine monstrosities? Imagine a battlefield where soldiers ride giant, fanged snake-tailed stallions into war—an utterly ludicrous scene.

– In **Revelation 10:9-10**, John is instructed to eat a book, which tastes sweet but turns bitter in his stomach. If taken literally, this means he sat down for a divine snack, munching on paper like a celestial goat.

– **Revelation 12:1** presents a woman standing on the moon, clothed with the sun, and wearing a crown of twelve stars. A literal reading suggests she is some kind of

celestial Romanian acrobat, defying gravity while accessorizing with flaming balls of gas.

– **Revelation 12:3-4** gives us a red dragon with seven heads and ten horns, whose apparent pastime is eating newborn babies. Are we expected to take this as a literal creature roaming the heavens, waiting for an infant buffet?

– In **Revelation 12:15-16**, the earth opens its mouth and swallows a river. At this point, the planet has developed a digestive system, complete with a gaping maw to gulp down natural disasters.

– In **Revelation 17:1-3**, John sees a prostitute riding a scarlet beast (does the beast come with saddle options?), a woman decked in luxury yet "drunk with the blood of the saints." It is also said to have committed fornication with the kings of the earth. If this isn't figurative, this would mean that instead of a chariot or airplane, she chose a giant red monster as her preferred mode of transportation, while drinking human blood and sleeping around with kings. If taken literally, it has diplomatic incident written all over it!

– In **Revelation 19:17-18**, an angel invites birds to a gruesome feast where they will gorge themselves on human flesh. If this is read literally, then God is apparently hosting a celestial barbecue with vultures as the VIP guests.

– The rider in **Revelation 19:15** wields a sword that comes out of his mouth to strike down the nations. One can only imagine the sheer impracticality of swinging a weapon with one's teeth while trying to deliver a battle speech.

– **Revelation 21:16** says the New Jerusalem is a perfect cube—1,500 miles wide, long, and high. If taken literally, that's stuffing a billion people into a floating cosmic Borg cube.

– **Revelation 22:1–2** features two magical trees whose fruit feeds all nations, planted on both sides of a single river. Expect extra long waiting time as the heavenly TSA manages those huge lines — much longer than the queue for the latest iPhone drop.

Thus, when read "as literally as possible," Revelation becomes a bizarre, impossible, and even comical spectacle. The absurdity of these images, when forced into a literal framework, reveals just how unnatural and illogical such an approach is. Instead of recognizing the book for what it is—an apocalyptic vision filled with profound symbolic messages—a literal interpretation turns it into an incoherent fantasy that disregards reason and reality entirely.

What Would a Symbolic Reading Look Like?

Interpreting a text symbolically does not necessarily contradict literal application. Symbolism and reality often coexist in biblical prophecy, where vivid imagery conveys deeper truths without necessarily linearly describing physical events in detail. Take **Daniel 7**, for example, where *"four great beasts, each different from the others, came up out of the sea."* While it's amusing to picture enormous creatures storming out of the ocean, trampling buildings, and causing mayhem like a Hollywood sci-fi spectacle, the passage is clearly not meant to be read as a literal event. Rather, each beast represents a kingdom or empire—historically understood as Babylon, Medo-Persia, Greece, and Rome. Because Israel is situated along the Mediterranean coastline, the imagery of rising from the sea has come to symbolize the arrival of foreign forces.

Similarly, **Isaiah 46:11** refers to *"a bird of prey from the east,"* which does not describe an actual predatory bird but likely symbolizes Cyrus the Great of Persia. This demonstrates how prophetic language often uses striking imagery to depict historical figures or geopolitical realities.

Now, let's apply this to the Book of Revelation. Take, for example, the **Mark (sign) of the Beast** (Revelation 13:16–18). Some contemporary evangelicals interpret this as a literal microchip, barcode, or vaccine that will be enforced in the end times. While such a scenario may one day unravel, to the first-century Jewish reader, the imagery of marks on the forehead and hand echoed something entirely different. In the Torah, Deuteronomy 6:8, God's commandments were to be bound *"as a sign on your hand"* and *"as frontlets between your eyes."* The sign/mark was seen as **a symbol of allegiance**—just as *"a seal on the foreheads of the servants of our God"* (Revelation 7:3) signified loyalty to God, not a literal seal/sign/mark embedded on their flesh by God.

Another example is the Revelation 13 **Beast**. John's original audience would have likely recognized the beast as a reference to **Rome**, the oppressive empire of their time. Its seven heads are explicitly said to be "seven hills" (Revelation 17:9), a clear allusion to Rome, known as *the city of seven hills*. Nero, the emperor infamous for persecuting Christians, is strongly linked to the beast, which becomes even more obvious when his name is calculated as the number 666 (using Hebrew numerology).

So, Why is a Symbolic Reading Often Taboo?

Among many Christians, the idea of reading Biblical texts symbolically rather than always literally is often seen as a compromise, a sign of weak faith, or even a lack of trust in God. This sentiment, however, is not based on reason but on an emotional appeal to fear and loyalty (known as the Appeal to Fear fallacy) rather than careful interpretation. In reality, **refusing to take Revelation at face value does not mean dismissing its truth; it means reading it as it was intended—in the rich, symbolic tradition of Jewish apocalyptic literature.**

To insist that only a literal reading is faithful is to ignore the genre, the historical context, and the way biblical prophecy has functioned in Judaism for thousands of years. Ironically, the very act of forcing a rigid, literal interpretation onto a highly symbolic text is what distorts its message, not the other way around!

Here is an example of this attitude—motivated by fear—from a sermon given in Calvary Chapel Community Church Oregon in 2024 titled, ***"Can We Take it Literally? | Revelation 1"***, where the pastor explains:

> **It's a literal interpretation of the future.** You will find out that most of my interpretations are literal. I take things literally unless the Bible uses the words "as" or "like" and that shows us that it's symbolic, but I take things as literally as I can until proven otherwise because I know that what I say is being listened to by The King and **I have to give an account** to him as to what I'm teaching.[11]
>
> CCC Church Oregon

It's certainly important to remain faithful to what the Bible teaches, as you will one day recount how you represented God. However, in this case, I believe fear may lead to the very opposite of the desired outcome.

The Purpose of Revelation: Encouragement, Not Fearful Speculation

When read in its Jewish context, Revelation ceases to be a literal end-time timetable and becomes what it was meant to be: a message of hope! It reassures the suffering church that, despite the apparent power of Rome (or any oppressive system), God reigns. Jesus, the slain Lamb, has already won the decisive victory. The imagery of judgment is not a prediction of a literal cataclysm but a dramatic way of affirming that the empires of this world will fall before God's justice.

By placing Revelation in its proper context, we avoid the sensationalism that often accompanies its interpretation, especially in certain evangelical circles. Revelation clearly wasn't intended to fuel endless obsessions about spooky blood moons, sinister microchips, magical sudden whisking away of a chosen few, or convenient political conspiracies. Instead, it was, and remains, a description of the ongoing struggle between God's kingdom and the forces of darkness in every generation, with a call to faithfulness.

Thus, the Jewishness of Revelation is not an obstacle to understanding it, but the key to unlocking its meaning. By reading it through the lens of Jewish apocalyptic thought, we move beyond a shallow literalism and see the book for what it truly is: a bold declaration that Jesus, the Messiah of Israel, is the Lord of history, and that His kingdom will prevail—not just in some distant future, but even now, wherever his followers remain faithful!

The Book of Daniel: The Backbone of Revelation

Before we explore the Book of Revelation, it would be beneficial to take a moment to quickly survey the Book of Daniel, found in the Hebrew Scriptures.

The Book of Daniel—written in both Hebrew and Aramaic—is a unique blend of narrative and prophecy, providing both historical accounts and apocalyptic visions. Set during the Babylonian exile after King Nebuchadnezzar's conquest of Jerusalem (6th century B.C.), Daniel and his three companions—Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego—are taken into captivity, yet they remain faithful to the God of Israel despite immense pressure to assimilate into Babylonian pagan culture. Their stories of perseverance, divine deliverance, and prophetic revelations make this book one of the most compelling in the Hebrew Scriptures.

Structure and Themes

The book is divided into two main sections:

1. **Chapters 1–6:** Historical narratives focusing on Daniel and his friends in Babylon. These stories highlight their unwavering faith and God's intervention, from surviving the fiery furnace (Ch. 3) and the lion's den (Ch. 6) to interpreting Nebuchadnezzar's dreams.
2. **Chapters 7–12:** Apocalyptic visions revealing the future of world kingdoms and the ultimate establishment of God's rule. These visions include the four beasts, each beast represents a kingdom (Ch. 7), the ram and the goat (Ch. 8), and the seventy weeks prophecy (Ch. 9) which many end-times enthusiasts love to argue over.

Key Themes

- **Faithfulness in Exile:** Daniel and his friends remain **faithful** in their worship of God despite persecution.
- **God's Sovereignty Over Kingdoms:** Earthly beastly-oppressive rulers and kingdoms are temporary and God will overcome them.
- **Prophecy and Eschatology:** Daniel's visions foretell future empires, the coming of the 'Son of Man,' and the ultimate victory of God's kingdom.

Apocalyptic Imagery and Its Link to Revelation

Daniel's prophetic visions are foundational to understanding Revelation, which builds upon his apocalyptic imagery. Some of the key parallels include:

1. **The Four Beasts and the Final Kingdom (Daniel 7 & Revelation 13, 17)**

   Daniel sees four beasts representing successive world empires/kingdoms, culminating in a final, terrifying beast with ten horns. As we will see, Revelation echoes this imagery, portraying a beast with ten horns that embodies oppressive world systems opposing God.

   - **The Lion with Eagle's Wings** – Represents **Babylon** (605–539 BC). The wings being plucked may symbolize Nebuchadnezzar's humbling before God (Daniel 4).
   - **The Bear Raised on One Side** – Represents **Medo-Persia** (539–331 BC). The raised side suggests Persia's dominance over the Medes. The three ribs in its mouth may symbolize its conquests (Babylon, Lydia, and Egypt).
   - **The Leopard with Four Wings and Four Heads** – Represents **Greece** (331–168 BC), led by **Alexander the Great**. The wings symbolize speed, and the four heads likely represent the division of his empire among his four generals after his death.
   - **The Terrifying Beast with Ten Horns** – Represents **Rome** (168 BC–476 AD). It is more dreadful than the others, with iron teeth and ten horns, indicating power and future divisions. From these horns emerges the **little horn**. The "little horn," described in Daniel (7:7-8, 20-25), symbolizes an arrogant, oppressive ruler or power that emerges after displacing three previous kingdoms, speaks defiantly against God, persecutes His people, and attempts to alter sacred times and laws. Historically,

this figure can be associated with Antiochus IV Epiphanes, the Seleucid king who desecrated the Jerusalem Temple in the 2nd century BC and severely persecuted the Jewish people. Yet, if seen as a reoccurring theme, the little horn could also point toward future antichrist figures throughout history—possibly culminating ultimately in a final, climactic Antichrist at the very end of time. Revelation (13:5-7) echoes similar imagery, describing a beast embodying characteristics that parallel Daniel's little horn, reinforcing this symbolic representation of oppressive, anti-God powers across both historical and future contexts.

2. Revelation 13 again describes a beast with features of the four beasts in Daniel (e.g., lion, bear, leopard), implying that oppressive world empires continue throughout history.
3. Both books point to God's ultimate victory, where the "Son of Man" (Daniel 7:13-14) will establish God's eternal kingdom, destroying the oppressiveness of old world systems.
4. In Daniel's vision, the "Son of Man" is exalted to sit at God's right hand and given dominion over all nations. Jesus applies this title to Himself (Mark 14:62), and Revelation presents Him returning in power, reigning as King over all (Rev. 1:7, 14:14).
5. The End of Oppressive Kingdoms (Daniel 2:44, 7:26-27 & Revelation 19:11-21)

    - In Daniel 2, King Nebuchadnezzar has a prophetic dream about a great statue composed of different materials, each symbolizing successive world empires. The head of gold represents the **Babylonian Empire** (Daniel 2:38), signifying its wealth and prominence. The chest and arms of silver depict the **Medo-Persian Empire** that would follow. The belly and thighs are made of bronze, symbolizing the **Greek Empire**, likely referring to the era of Alexander the Great. The legs of iron symbolize the

Roman empire, known historically for its strength and ruthless power in conquering and subduing enemies.

The statue's feet, composed of iron mixed with clay, symbolize a kingdom that emerges after the Roman Empire, characterized by internal instability and division. Daniel 2:43 clarifies this imagery: *"As you saw iron mixed with soft clay, so they will mix with one another in marriage, but they will not hold together, just as iron does not mix with clay."* The iron mixed with clay represents a fragmented and unstable kingdom that, possibly, attempts to unite through political alliances. However, these efforts ultimately fail, resulting in an empire with superficial strength but fundamental internal weakness.

Although verse 43 has been a subject of much debate and speculation, and several other interpretations are indeed feasible, historically, this mixture of iron and clay has often been interpreted as representing the fragmented state of Europe following the decline and division of the Roman Empire. Despite multiple attempts at unity through political alliances and marriages, Europe remained divided and unstable, unable to achieve lasting cohesion.

Theologically, the vision concludes with a stone striking and destroying the fragile statue (representing human empires). This stone symbolizes the eternal Kingdom established by God Himself, supplanting and transcending all human empires and kingdoms. Revelation describes Christ's final victory over earthly powers, where Babylon (representing the corrupt world systems) is shattered.

6. The Resurrection and Final Judgment (Daniel 12:2-3 & Revelation 20:11-15)

    - Daniel speaks of a resurrection where the righteous shine like stars while the wicked face great shame and disgrace. Revelation

expands this with the final judgment, where the dead are judged according to their deeds.

The Book's Relevance

Daniel's hope and message transcends its immediate historical context, offering a promise to persecuted believers throughout history. His visions reveal that human kingdoms, when all they thirst for is endless power and wealth, and exalt themselves above God, become oppressive and beastly. Yet, the book assures that God's justice will prevail, culminating in the reign of the 'Son of Man.'

Revelation carries forward this theme, presenting Christ as the ultimate fulfillment of Daniel's prophecies. Together, these books provide a powerful eschatological vision that encourages faithfulness amid suffering and confidence in God's ultimate victory.

Interpreting Daniel this way offers enduring hope to people in every generation. It shows that even when evil seems to prevail, God is fully aware and has a plan to overcome what we see—though it may not unfold in our lifetime. It reminds us that many before us have faced similar trials and dark moments, and like them, we are called to trust in God's greater purpose and wait for God's final and ultimate restoration of all things (Acts 3:21).

The Bible Project

I hope you have enjoyed the first part of the book! Before we move on, it's time for a brief break…

Overall, *The Bible Project* offers an interpretation of the Bible that remains faithful to its Jewish origins—an interpretation that, for the most part, aligns with my own perspective. Thus, I strongly suggest taking a few minutes to view their two brief animated videos on Revelation (ten minutes each); it is definitely worth your time. You can use the link below or scan the barcode with your smartphone.

Scan or Visit:

www.eitan.bar/watch-revelation

Revelation 1-3: The Seven Churches

John begins his book with a powerful declaration:

> *The **revelation** from Jesus Christ, which God gave him to show his servants what must soon take place.*
>
> Revelation 1:1

The very first word of the book, *apokalypsis*, means "revelation" or "unveiling." Unlike the modern use of "apocalypse," which conjures images of chaos, destruction and the end of the world, its biblical meaning refers to a divine disclosure—a revealing of secrets or uncovering of existing truth previously concealed or obscured. Here, John receives God's perspective on the human narrative, showing how the present world will ultimately be transformed by His divine plan.

A Prophecy—to Warn and Comfort

John makes it clear that this vision was not his own invention but a prophecy. In Biblical prophecy, future events are rarely the focus.

I once read that an estimate of about 20-25% of biblical prophecy concerns future events, including Messianic prophecies, eschatological visions, and the final judgment. The remaining 75-80% addresses current situations during the prophets'

lifetimes—offering warnings, calls for repentance, corrections, and messages of hope and restoration for the people of Israel and surrounding nations. Regardless of how accurate these numbers are, they suggest that to read the text faithfully, we must understand it within its original context and draw meaning from it—rather than projecting our own modern culture, news and assumptions onto it. In other words: exegesis, not eisegesis.

John tells us that this revelation is something that *"must soon take place"* (Revelation 1:1). For many readers, this statement is challenging since nearly 2,000 years have passed. As we will soon learn, most—but not all—of the events of Revelation indeed took place or were about to take place in John's day. However, and as we previously established, Jewish prophecy often operates in patterns and cycles rather than fixed chronological predictions. The underlying idea continues to repeat in different forms throughout history, culminating in their ultimate fulfillment.

Revelation recounts John's visions that unveil God's heavenly perspective on history —not merely to provide a timeline of future events, but to reveal deeper spiritual realities. These texts use rich symbolic imagery and numerical patterns, not to confuse but to communicate profound truths. Nearly every vision in Revelation is woven from Old Testament imagery and other Jewish apocalyptic writings, and John expects his readers to recognize these references and interpret them accordingly.

While Revelation contains messages relevant to all Christians throughout history, its meaning must be anchored in the historical context of John's time and place. The struggles faced by the seven churches in Asia Minor provide the framework for understanding how the book's themes—faithfulness, resistance to evil, and the ultimate victory of the Lamb—apply to every generation. What happened to these churches is part of a much larger, repeating pattern, one that continues to unfold even today.

John's Audience: The Seven Churches of Asia Minor

John states that he is writing to seven churches in the Roman province of Asia (modern-day Turkey).

Why these seven churches? There were certainly more than seven Christian communities in the region, so this selection was intentional. These churches were

chosen not just for their historical reality but because they represent the spiritual conditions of the global Church throughout history. Each receives a prophetic message from Jesus—sometimes encouragement, sometimes rebuke—teaching what faithfulness looks like and what compromises must be rejected.

The number seven is not random—it is a symbol of divine completeness and perfection in the Hebrew Scriptures. We see this, for example, in the seven days of creation (Genesis 1), the seven lamps in the Tabernacle (Exodus 25:37), and the seven times Israel marched around Jericho (Joshua 6:15-16). Revelation is saturated with sevens: seven seals (Revelation 6:1), seven trumpets (Revelation 8:6), seven bowls (Revelation 16:1), and seven spirits before God's throne (Revelation 1:4).

John's Vision on Patmos

John tells us that he received his vision while exiled on the island of Patmos (Revelation 1:9). Patmos was a barren island in the Aegean Sea, used by the Romans to imprison political and religious dissidents. Since early Christians refused to worship the emperor, they were often seen as subversive threats to the empire. John's exile was likely part of the growing persecution under Emperor Domitian (81–96 AD), who saw Christianity as a challenge to Roman authority.

It is here, in isolation, that John receives a vision of the risen Jesus standing among seven golden lampstands (Revelation 1:20). This imagery is drawn from Zechariah 4, where a golden lampstand represents God's presence among His people. In Revelation, the lampstands symbolize the seven churches. Jesus, clothed in radiant divine glory, walks among them, a symbol of His intimate knowledge of their struggles and His supreme authority over the Church.

Faithfulness or Compromise? The Message to the Seven Churches

In John's prophecy, Jesus addresses each of the seven churches, offering both commendation and correction. These churches faced different challenges—some

were spiritually complacent, others had fallen into moral compromise, and some endured harassment and persecution.

— **Ephesus (Revelation 2:1-7)**—Known for its doctrinal purity but lacking love. They were zealous in guarding truth but had forgotten their first love—they had drifted from their initial passion, becoming more focused on religious duty than expressing God's love. Today, this looks like churches or believers who are theologically dedicated and zealous for truth but have become cold, rigid, or legalistic, prioritizing doctrine over love and missing the heart of the gospel.

— **Smyrna (Revelation 2:8-11)**—Faithful amid suffering. This church faced intense persecution, yet Jesus encouraged them to remain steadfast even unto death. Today, this looks like underground churches and persecuted Christians in places like China, North Korea, or other parts of Asia and the Middle East, who endure imprisonment, violence, or even death for their faith but remain steadfast in their commitment to Jesus.

— **Pergamum (Revelation 2:12-17)**—Struggled with compromise. Some members had embraced false teachings, leading to idolatry and immorality. Today, this looks like churches or believers watering down biblical truths and blending Christianity with idolatry. For instance, those influenced by the prosperity gospel, where faith is compromised by the pursuit of wealth.

— **Thyatira (Revelation 2:18-29)**—Tolerated a false prophetess (Jezebel), who led many into corruption and moral failure. Today, this looks like churches or believers who allow charismatic but deceptive leaders to manipulate and mislead people, often promoting spiritual corruption, greed, or moral compromise under the guise of prophecy or special revelation. This can be seen in cult-like movements, some televangelists, or religious figures who exploit their followers for power or financial gain.

As for Jezebel in Thyatira, she may not have been a literal person but rather a symbolic reference to the "spirit of Jezebel," aka deception and corruption, much like the historical Jezebel in 1 and 2 Kings, who led Israel into idolatry and immorality. The name could also represent a group, an ideology, or a corrupt leader who was influencing the church at the time.

Notice that the "heads-up" the Church in Thyatira received (Revelation 2:27) is a direct quote from Psalm 2:9: *"You will break them with a rod of iron; you will dash them to pieces like pottery."*

You might appreciate the explanation offered by Eusebius of Caesarea (c. 260–340 AD):

> *The Son 'breaking in pieces' His enemies is for the sake of remolding them, as a potter his own work; as Jeremiah 18:6 says: i.e., to restore them once again to their former state.* [12]

— **Sardis (Revelation 3:1-6)**—A spiritually dead church. They had a reputation for being alive, but their faith was lifeless. Today, this looks like churches and ministries that turned into "clubs"; they appear vibrant on the outside—full of activity, programs, newsletters, online presence, and large gatherings—but are spiritually empty, relying on tradition, reputation, or past success rather than genuine faith, transformation, and dependence on the Holy Spirit.

— **Philadelphia (Revelation 3:7-13)**—A faithful remnant. Jesus praises them for keeping His word despite opposition. Today, this looks like small but faithful churches or believers who remain committed to Christ and His teachings despite cultural pressure, opposition, or marginalization—often unnoticed by the world but deeply valued in God's Kingdom.

— **Laodicea (Revelation 3:14-22)**—Lukewarm and self-reliant. This church had become comfortable and complacent, neither hot nor cold, prompting Jesus to say, “I will spit you out of my mouth” (Revelation 3:16). Today, this looks like churches and ministries that prioritize diplomacy over truth, afraid to challenge or confront anything for fear of offending, resulting in a faith that is inoffensive, comfortable, and ineffective—neither passionate in conviction nor openly opposed to sin and injustice, ultimately making no real impact.

These churches are both historical and symbolic. Throughout Christian history, some churches resemble Philadelphia, remaining faithful despite persecution, while others mirror Laodicea, relying on wealth and comfort instead of true devotion.

Faithfulness as Conquering

Faithfulness in Revelation is not mere religious dogmatic stubbornness—it's not about how long your sleeves are or how orthodox your theology is, but a call to remain loyal to Christ's ways despite external pressures. The Roman Empire, much like oppressive regimes throughout history, demanded ultimate allegiance, often forcing believers to choose between social, economic, or even physical survival and their commitment to Jesus. John's message to these churches is clear: genuine victory —true conquering—comes not through violent resistance or fearful submission, but through unwavering trust.

By the time John sent his letter, the brutal persecution under Nero had passed, and a similar wave of tribulation under Emperor Domitian was in motion. Emperor Domitian persecuted Christians by enforcing emperor worship, exiling leaders like John to Patmos, and executing those who refused to acknowledge him as "Lord and God" through beheadings, crucifixions, burning at the stake, and throwing them to wild animals in the arena. The temptation to compromise and deny Jesus was overwhelming.

Jesus calls the churches to faithfulness, urging them to "conquer" (a war term), for by remaining steadfast, they would receive a reward in the final marriage of Heaven and Earth (Revelation 21-22). This was an opportunity for them to be rewarded in God's future kingdom with a position of honor and greatness, symbolized by becoming "pillars" in God's temple (Revelation 3:12).

Western Christianity often reduces salvation to a binary choice—heaven or hell —but the biblical reality is richer. Jesus spoke of varying rewards in the Kingdom (Matthew 5:19), indicating that faithfulness shapes one's role in the world to come. However, remaining faithful is not about rigid legalism. Faithfulness is about trust, perseverance, and a commitment to Jesus's Way (Matthew 5-7) even amid hardship. It's easy to love others when life is comfortable, but far more difficult when you're struggling to survive. Loving your enemies, as Jesus commanded, becomes especially challenging when they mock your faith and even seek to harm you, yet this is what *conquering* looks like in the Kingdom of God.

Thus, to remain faithful does not mean clinging to religious laws for their own sake. Many confuse faithfulness with legalistic rigidity, but in Revelation, sacrificial love and endurance define true faithfulness. Faithfulness is demonstrated through choosing love over hatred, mercy over retaliation, and trust over fear.

This sets up the book's core tension: Will God's people "conquer" (Revelation 3:5) despite persecution and hardship? And why does Revelation frequently draw on the language of war and military conquest?[13] As the book unfolds, John reveals the answer—faithfulness is the means by which believers participate in the cosmic warfare against evil—a spiritual battle not fought with swords and violence, but through endurance, sacrificial love, and unwavering trust. Thus, to conquer is not to kill one's enemies, but to love them as the Lamb did.

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Some argue that Revelation 3:10 — *"I will keep you from the hour of trial"* — implies a pre-tribulation rapture of the Church. However, in my view, this interpretation takes the verse out of context and reads into it assumptions that are not there. I spent 20 years within a dispensationalist movement and studied the rapture extensively at two prominent evangelical institutions — including Dallas Theological Seminary, the academic stronghold of pre-tribulation rapture theology. Ironically, it was during my time there that I began to seriously question, and ultimately reject, the validity of this theory. I came to believe that the pre-tribulation rapture view is not only unsupported by Scripture but misrepresents the very heart of the Gospel message.

However, I will not be discussing the rapture in this book, as I've already offered a refutation of the concept of a pre-tribulation rapture in detail in my short book, ***Left Behind Deconstructed: Why I Left Pre-Tribulation Rapture Behind***.

Revelation 4-5: The Heavenly Throne Room and First Judgment

This is where it gets interesting. John's next vision transports him into God's heavenly throne room, a scene filled with magnificent eschatological imagery, all drawn from previously written prophetic books. This moment is pivotal in Revelation, as it establishes God's absolute authority over history and prepares the way for the unfolding of divine judgment and redemption. The throne room is not merely a setting; it is a symbol of God's sovereignty over heaven and earth.

As John is taken up in the Spirit, he sees God seated on the throne (Revelation 4:2). This vision parallels the throne scenes in Isaiah 6, where the prophet sees the Lord "high and exalted," and Ezekiel 1, where God appears above a dazzling chariot-throne.

Surrounding the throne are twenty-four elders dressed in white, symbolizing the twelve tribes of Israel and the twelve apostles, representing the fullness of God's people throughout history (Revelation 4:4).

Also present are four living creatures, reminiscent of Ezekiel's vision, embodying all creation—wild animals, domesticated beasts, birds, and humans—worshiping their Creator (Ezekiel 1:5-14; Revelation 4:6-8). These creatures ceaselessly proclaim:

> *Holy, holy, holy is the Lord God Almighty, who was, and is, and is to come.*
>
> Revelation 4:8

This proclamation echoes Isaiah 6:3, where the seraphim cry out the same words in God's presence. The tripling of "holy" emphasizes God's absolute purity, transcendence, and perfection.

The Sealed Scroll: Who Is Worthy?

In the right hand of the One seated on the throne, John sees a sealed scroll (Revelation 5:1). Some translations, like the KJV, translate the word "scroll" in Revelation as "book".[14] This scroll/book is sealed with seven seals, emphasizing that its contents are fully secured, divinely decreed, and inaccessible to any human being. In other words, no one is able to usher God's promised kingdom.

The imagery of a sealed book/scroll appears in the Old Testament:

- **Isaiah 8:16** speaks of God sealing up His testimony among His disciples.
- **Ezekiel 2-3** describes a scroll filled with lamentation, which Ezekiel is commanded to eat.
- **Daniel 12:4, 9** tells of a prophecy sealed.

This strongly suggests that the scroll in Revelation represents God's divine plan for the world's redemption, His decree for the unfolding of salvation through judgment. It symbolize the culmination of the Old Testament prophetic writings, longing for God's promised redemption.

However, a dramatic tension unfolds—**no one is found worthy to open the scroll** (Revelation 5:3). John begins to weep bitterly, realizing that if the scroll remains closed, God's purposes will remain unknown or, worse, unfulfilled, and justice will not be carried out.

This scene may seem confusing, but gaining insight into Israel's priesthood can provide clarity. In ancient Israel, the priest stood at the intersection between heaven and earth. A priest was not simply a religious official performing rituals — a priest was a representative. The priest bore the name, identity, and hopes of Israel before the living God. He was Israel's ambassador.

But Israel's priests were limited, temporary, flawed. They were only shadows. No priest could truly represent Israel perfectly before God. Their sacrifices had to be repeated. Their own sins had to be atoned for before they could intercede for others.

This is why the apostle John, in his heavenly vision, broke down in tears when he saw the scroll of God's ultimate purposes sealed shut — because no one in heaven or on earth was found worthy to open it. Creation longed for a priest — a true mediator to unlock the scroll — but none could be found.

The Lion and the Lamb

Then, one of the elders tells John:

> *Do not weep! See, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has triumphed. He is able to open the scroll and its seven seals.*
>
> Revelation 5:5

The **Lion of Judah** (Genesis 49:9) and the **Root of David** (Isaiah 11:1) are Messianic titles in Judaism, evoking the mighty, conquering King from the line of David who many expected to bring God's kingdom through military victory.

But in a shocking twist, John sees not a lion, but a little slain lamb:

> *Then I saw a Lamb, looking as if it had been slain, standing at the center of the throne.*
>
> Revelation 5:6

The term "lamb" in Revelation is the Greek word ἀρνίον (*arnion*), a "lambkin" similar to the Passover Lamb, portraying Jesus' meekness, innocence, and sacrificial act as he initiates God's kingdom. Perhaps C. S. Lewis' Aslan is a good depiction of the lion in Revelation—the "Warrior King" of the animals who fought evil by dying for his friends.

Instead of conquering through violence, Jesus sacrificed Himself for His enemies, embodying the role of the true Lamb. Just as the blood of the lamb in Exodus (Exodus 12) symbolized protection and cleansing of sin, Jesus' sacrifice brings redemption—purification not just of Israel's sins, but of the entire world (John 1:29). His victory was not through military conquest, as many expected of the Messiah, but through self-giving love, which broke the power of sin and death. By laying down His life, He inverted the primal human instinct of power—instead of defeating His enemies by force; He defeated evil itself by absorbing its worst blow and overcoming it through resurrection.

This stunning reversal is key to understanding Revelation's radical message. The Messianic conqueror is described as a roaring lion, yet He does not conquer through war or force, but through self-sacrifice—He is a slain yet victorious Lamb. His power is not in military might, but in laying down His life, turning the world's definition of conquest upside down.

This imagery recalls not only the Passover lamb but also Isaiah's Suffering Servant, who was *"led like a lamb to the slaughter"* (Isaiah 53:7). Here, too, instead of military conquest, the Suffering Servant conquered through self-sacrifice. His victory is not through shedding others' blood, but through offering His own precious blood!

One lesson we still haven't learned in 2,000 years is that Jesus wielded neither political power nor military might, yet we continue trying to change the world the same way Rome did—through force, fear, and manipulation. But in the end, who truly triumphed? The empire that ruled with an iron fist is long gone, while the message of a crucified divine Jewish rabbi continues to transform hearts across the world!

The Lamb's Victory Over Evil

This reversal is essential for grasping the message of Revelation. Jesus' death was not a defeat—it was His enthronement, His conquering of sin, death, and evil. By dying and resurrecting, Jesus overcomes the power of death (Hebrews 2:14). By suffering, He defeats the forces of evil (Colossians 2:15). By offering Himself, He ransoms people for God (Revelation 5:9).

Thus, Jesus, the slain Lamb, alone is worthy to open the scroll. He takes it from the One on the throne, and heaven erupts into worship. The angels, elders and other creatures—representing all of creation—sing:

> *Worthy is the Lamb, who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and strength and honor and glory and praise!*
>
> Revelation 5:12

Perhaps this is a glimpse of what it might sound like the day *"every tongue confesses that Jesus Christ is Lord"* (Philippians 2:11).

Interestingly, the Lamb shares divine authority with God. He is worshiped not separately from God, but as one worship God.

Jesus' Kingdom: The Upside-Down Rule of Love

Jesus' kingdom is unlike any earthly empire. In Matthew 5-7, Jesus describes His kingdom as one where:

- Not the strong and wealthy, but the humble, meek, and persecuted are blessed.
- Enemies are to be loved, not hated.
- Sinners are to be forgiven, not stoned.

This kingdom of self-giving love contrasts with Rome, Babylon, and every other empire ever since that seeks power through domination. It's not by chance that **Revelation repeatedly contrasts the beastly way (power, oppression, violence) with the Lamb's way (sacrificial love, compassion, meekness).**

The Three Cycles of Sevens: Unfolding Judgment

The Lamb's act of taking the scroll initiates the unfolding of history. What follows is a series of three judgments, each structured around seven:

1. The Seven Seals (Revelation 6-8:1).
2. The Seven Trumpets (Revelation 8:2-11:19).
3. The Seven Bowls (Revelation 15-16).

These judgments do not depict a simple chronological sequence, but rather three overlapping perspectives on the same period of time—the era between Jesus' ascending and His second return. However, judgment in the Book of Revelation—as themed throughout the Bible—is not merely punitive but ultimately redemptive. God's judgment always culminates in redemption.[15]

Some people read these sevens as a rigid timeline of future events. However, John weaves them together in a layered recursive structure. The seventh seal leads to the trumpets, the seventh trumpet introduces the bowls, and each cycle culminates in the final judgment.

An effective metaphor might be likened to nesting dolls or a spiral staircase—each iteration leads us back to the same fundamental truths, yet allows us to view them from an elevated standpoint. Each time, we see God's justice and mercy unfolding in different ways.

Conclusion: The Lamb Reigns, Even When You Still Can't See It

Revelation 4-5 establishes the foundation for everything that follows. Before the judgments of history are revealed, we must first understand who reigns over history.

The answer is clear: God rules from His throne, and the slain Lamb shares that throne as the rightful King of all creation.

As the seals, trumpets, and bowls unfold, the central question remains: Will we align ourselves with the way of the beast—power, domination, and violence? Or will we follow the way of the Lamb—sacrificial love, faithfulness, and endurance? Revelation calls us to see reality through God's perspective and recognize that, no matter how chaotic the world appears, the Lamb is on the throne, and His kingdom will prevail.

Revelation 6-7: The Lord's Slain Servants

As the Lamb begins to open the seals of the divine scroll, John witnesses a symbolic vision—the release of four horsemen, one by one (Revelation 6:1-8). This image is drawn directly from Zechariah (1:8-11 and 6:1-8), where four horses are patrolling the earth and its world affairs.

The Four Horsemen

Each horse in Revelation represents a different force at work throughout human history:

1. **White Horse: Conquest, Domination** — The White Horse in Revelation 6:2 (the first seal) is debated — because of the color of the horse, there are those who see it as hinting to Christ. However, a white horse in the ancient world symbolized triumph and was especially used by generals and kings during victory parades (like Roman triumphs). Thus, the white horse represents deception, oppressive rulers, or militaristic conquest. Given the context of the other Horsemen (war, famine, death), it is more likely a symbol of human conquest and imperial domination rather than Christ (who rides a white horse in Revelation 19:11, but in an entirely different context).
2. **Red Horse: War, Conflict** — The rider takes peace from the earth, leading to bloodshed and destruction (Revelation 6:4).
3. **Black Horse: Famine, Suffering** — A measure of wheat for a denarius, highlighting economic oppression, where basic sustenance becomes unaffordable for the poor (Revelation 6:5-6).
4. **Pale Green Horse: Death, Grave** — The final rider represents death and destruction, following in the wake of war and famine (Revelation 6:8).

This vision should not be seen as a prediction of a single future event but as an ongoing theme—these four forces have shaped human history since the beginning. Let's quickly examine the forth horse as an example:

> *And I looked, and behold a pale horse: and his name that sat on him was Death, and Hell followed with him. And power was given unto them over the fourth part of the earth, to kill with sword, and with hunger, and with death, and with the beasts of the earth.*
>
> Revelation 6:8

Throughout human history, war, famine, disease, and ultimately death have been constant realities—this is what the pale horse and its rider, Death, symbolize in Revelation 6:8. They do not represent a specific future event, but rather the ongoing cycle that has plagued humanity since the beginning of time. These forces have always been at work, shaping civilizations and reminding us of the fragile nature of life.

For instance, we like to call the last two major conflicts "World War I" and "World War II," but that labeling can be misleading. It implies they were the first global-scale wars — when in reality, history is filled with countless earlier wars that engulfed multiple nations and continents. From ancient empires clashing across regions to colonial powers waging battles around the globe, there were likely hundreds, if not thousands, of "world wars" long before the 20th century. The difference is not their scale, but that we only started calling them "world wars" recently.

The verse also states that *"**Hell** followed with him,"* but the Greek word used here is actually *Hades*, which does not refer to the Augustinian-Calvinist interpretation of eternal torment in Hellfire, but rather the realm of the dead—the Great Grave of the ancient world. In biblical thought, *Hades* is the temporary place where the dead are asleep, awaiting final resurrection and judgment.[16] The "hell follows death" imagery reinforces the grim reality of death's dominion over humanity—wherever death goes, the grave follows it.

Incidentally (or not), the colors of the four horses (green, black, red, white) also parallel the dominant colors of most Islamic nations. And sometimes, the four caliphs of Islam are depicted as riders on four horses…

The Cry of the Martyrs: How Long, Lord?

As the fifth seal is opened, John sees the souls of the slain martyrs beneath the altar (Revelation 6:9-11). These faithful witnesses cry out for justice, asking, *"How long, Sovereign Lord?"* (Revelation 6:10). This echoes the cry of the psalmists and the prophets:

> *How long, Lord, will the wicked be jubilant?*
>
> Psalm 94:3

> *How long before you judge those who destroy the earth?*
>
> Jeremiah 12:4

> *How long, LORD, must I call for help, but you do not listen? Or cry out to you, "Violence!" but you do not save?*
>
> Habakkuk 1:2

The response is bittersweet: they are given white robes (symbolizing their vindication) but are told to ***wait*** (Revelation 6:11), as more believers will be martyred before justice is complete. This waiting period is a reminder that while suffering and persecution will continue, they are not interruptions of God's plan but a part of it, even for the righteous.

You see, humanity cannot truly learn and progress unless it suffers, because suffering forces individuals, societies and ultimately humanity, to confront its own corruption, question common assumptions, and seek deeper truths. Comfort often breeds complacency, but pain awakens the soul to change, compelling growth in wisdom, empathy, and resilience. History shows that many of the greatest moral, scientific, and spiritual breakthroughs emerged not in times of ease but through trials —whether through war, injustice, or personal loss. Suffering, while painful, becomes

the refining fire of hell that shapes character, purifies the hearts, and drives the pursuit of justice, meaning, and transformation.

The story of Job powerfully illustrates this truth. A righteous man, Job does not suffer because of wrongdoing, but because his life becomes a stage for a cosmic drama between good and evil. His pain is not punishment, but purpose—transforming him into an eternal symbol of human struggle, faith, and endurance. Through his suffering, humanity gains a story to wrestle with, reflect upon, and learn from across generations. Indeed, Job's story became a microcosm of apocalyptic suffering.

Interestingly, Job—like many others throughout history—experienced the Four Horsemen of Revelation in symbolic form:

1. **Violence** – Job loses his wealth to raiders.
2. **Conquest** – His property was taken away.
3. **Suffering** – Job is impoverished by disaster and loss and he suffers disease.
4. **Death** – His children die.

War, conquest, famine and death are not unique to the book of Revelation or to any point in time, past, present or future. Thousands of years ago, Job, like the martyrs in Revelation or those of today, endures suffering while waiting for God's justice.

A timely example: as I'm writing these very lines—Early 2025—Islamic militants have committed a tragic act in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC). On February 12, 2025, members of the Islamic ADF abducted over 70 Christian civilians from the village of Mayba in North Kivu's Lubero Territory. The captives were taken to a Protestant church in the nearby village of Kasanga, where they were executed by beheading. Their bodies were discovered two days later.[17]

Likewise, on March 2025, a horrific massacre of Christians took place in Syria, only a couple of hours away from where I live. In just a few days, local Muslims slaughtered about a thousand Christians in Syria's coastal region.[18]

These atrocities are merely a minor example of the reality many Middle Eastern Christians live in today. Yet, they underscore that Christians have endured severe tribulations throughout history and still face them across the world today (John

15:20, Matthew 24:9). Tribulations don't have to mean a beheading or a nuclear disaster; it can also be something as personal as your Muslim boss firing you for becoming a Christian and you can no longer afford to feed your baby. True story.

When the sixth seal is opened, the earth trembles (Revelation 6:12-17). The imagery here is unmistakably symbolizing the Day of the Lord, as described by the Hebrew prophets (e.g., Isaiah 2:10-21 and Joel 2:30-31). The sun turns black; the moon turns to blood, and the heavens are shaken. The people of the earth cry out, *"Who can stand?"* (Revelation 6:17). Justice is about to be served!

This question—**Who is able to stand?**—is not about physically falling because people are melting in fire, but it's also not rhetorical. John pauses to answer it in the next scene.

The 144,000: Who Are They?

John sees an angel with a signet ring, marking God's servants for protection (Revelation 7:2-3). He then hears the number 144,000. This is not a new cult finally reaching 144,000 members, but comprise 12,000 from each of the twelve tribes of Israel (Revelation 7:4-8). This number is deeply **symbolic** in both Jewish and biblical tradition. The number 12 symbolizes God's covenant people (12 tribes, 12 apostles, 12 stones in the high priest's breastplate). Likewise, Israel was often numbered in thousands by tribe (e.g., Numbers 1, 26), especially prior to military battles (e.g., Numbers 31).

However, just as John *heard* that the Lion of Judah would conquer but *saw* a little slain lamb (Revelation 5:5-6), here he *hears* about the 144,000 Israelites but then turns and *sees* a great multitude from every nation (Revelation 7:9). Symbolically, the nation of Israel — the Jewish people — is like the "starter culture" of God's kingdom, the original seed through which the blessings of God would begin to spread. This kingdom was always meant to expand and be filled with multitudes of Gentiles, grafted in through faith.

That's why, as Paul writes in Romans 11:18, Gentile believers are not to *"boast over the branches"* — referring to Israel — but to show humility and honor toward their older brother in faith. After all, it is through Israel that the covenants, the prophets, the Scriptures, and the Messiah Himself came (Romans 9:4–5).

Either way, this multinational army of the Lamb fulfills God's ancient promise to Abraham:

> *I have made you a father of many nations.*
>
> Genesis 17:4

Obviously, more than just 144,000 were redeemed, and this number should not be taken literally (can someone please let Jehovah's Witnesses know?). Rather, it symbolizes the fullness of God's people, drawn from every nation, tribe, and language (Revelation 7:9). They are the Lamb's army, but unlike earthly armies, they do not conquer by killing—they overcome through suffering, sacrificial love, and bearing faithful witness, just as the Lamb Himself did. Thus, "staying faithful" truly means imitating the Lamb's self-giving love.

Faithfulness Is Not Pacifism

At this point, some may wonder: Am I suggesting Revelation teaches Absolute Pacifism?

No, this does not mean passivity in the face of evil. Sacrificial love is not pacifism—it is a willingness to do what Jesus did—sacrifice your life to look after those you love. It is an active resistance to evil through righteousness, truth, and unwavering faithfulness.

Although in disagreement over some things, there are other things I absolutely admire about liberal Christians — especially their deep understanding of God's mercy and compassion toward all people and the need for better loving our enemies. However, I believe there's a blind spot.

Just because war is never the morally ideal or most desirable choice doesn't mean we shouldn't defend ourselves or protect future generations. Sometimes, war isn't about choosing violence — it's about refusing to surrender to it. Peace is always the goal, but justice and protection are often the necessary path to reach it.

While believers are called to love their enemies and suffer without retaliation, love also means protecting others from harm, since *"love always protects"* (1 Corinthians 13:7). Yes, Jesus rebuked Peter for using violence (Matthew 26:52), but He also violently drove out the money changers (John 2:15). Loving one's enemy never meant allowing injustice to thrive.

Thus, true faithfulness in Revelation means resisting evil without fearing or becoming like it. The cycle of revenge is endless, but sacrificial love has the potential to break it.

Conclusion: The Pattern of Suffering and Redemption

Revelation 6-7 reveals a cosmic pattern that has played out in every single generation since the beginning of time.

Over the past 2,000 years, an estimated 700 million to 1.25 billion people may have died due to wars and diseases alone. This figure is a rough estimate, as historical records are incomplete, especially for earlier periods.

Regardless of the exact number, the point is that most people in every generation have lived through suffering, instability, and the looming reality of death. Plagues, wars, famines, and political turmoil are not just future events; they are challenges that have influenced human history, often rendering life delicate and unpredictable.

This is why most Christian generations have believed they were living in the last days—because in a sense they were. These events of Revelation are not confined to a single end-time scenario but are patterns that repeat until the final fulfillment. However, final fulfillment means there will be one last culminating event or else we'll keep going forever. And that last event will be filled with action!

Every era has seen war, conquest, famine, and death. Every empire has oppressed the faithful. Every generation of believers has faced persecution and martyrdom. The idea that we live in uniquely apocalyptic times is largely a matter of perspective—every era has had its own crises that felt like the end of the world. And yet, every generation has also seen God at work, preserving His people and advancing His kingdom. The crucial difference is that today, the Jews are back in the Land of Israel, and that's theologically significant!

Thus, the real question in the Book of Revelation is not *"When will these things happen?"* but *"Who will remain faithful through them?"* The answer is clear:

- Those sealed by God, marked not with a physical sign, but by their faithfulness to the Lamb.
- Those who overcome, not by violence, but by endurance.
- Those who understand that conquering and being faithful means loving, sacrificing, and bearing witness to the truth.

The Lamb is leading His army—not to bloodshed, but to victory through faithfulness. The question remains: **Are we willing to serve in Christ's army?**

Revelation 8-11: Judgment, Temple, and Two Witnesses

When the seventh and final seal is broken, something unexpected happens—silence (Revelation 8:1).

This silence prepares for the next stage of judgment. Before the full wrath of God is unleashed, John sees seven trumpets emerge from the seventh seal—a reminder that the structure of Revelation is not linear but recursive, with each cycle unveiling the same reality from a different perspective.

The seven trumpets do not present a new series of events but retell the story from another angle, this time using imagery from Israel's Exodus from Egypt. Just as God sent plagues upon Egypt to challenge Pharaoh and deliver His people, these trumpet judgments fall upon oppressive nations, a wake up call to repentance.

The Seven Trumpets and Echoes of Exodus

The first five trumpets parallel the plagues of Exodus (Revelation 8:6-12): Hail and fire (Revelation 8:7) echoes the plague of hail and fire in Egypt (Exodus 9:23-24). Blood in the sea and poisoned waters (Revelation 8:8-11) parallels the Nile turning to blood and becoming undrinkable (Exodus 7:20-21). Darkness (Revelation 8:12) reflects the ninth plague of darkness (Exodus 10:21-23). Demon Locusts (Revelation 9:1-11) are like the locust plague on Egypt, but now these locusts are demonic figures with terrifying power (Exodus 10:12-15).

These judgments do not come all at once, but unfold as warnings, much like the plagues in Egypt. However, John tells us something crucial—despite these judgments, the nations still do not repent (Revelation 9:20-21). This mirrors Pharaoh's hardened heart; even when faced with divine punishment, he refused to yield to God.

The Limits of Judgment and the Magic of Grace

This section of Revelation brings us to a profound theological conclusion—**judgment alone does not change the human heart**. Like Egypt, oppressive empires resist repentance even when faced with judgment and devastation, which ultimately leads to their fall.

This is also true in our personal lives and society. Punishment and suffering may deter people from external wrongdoing, but they rarely produce true inner transformation. Laws and consequences may restrain evil, but only mercy, grace, and love can change the heart. This is also the crucial contrast between the Law and the New Covenant:

- The **Law** (punishment, judgment, plagues) exposes sin but does not create righteousness.
- **Grace** (forgiveness, sacrificial love, patience, mercy) is what truly transforms people.

Thus, to be victorious like Christ, according to Revelation, is not through judgment and vengeance, but through grace, which alone holds the power to transform hearts.

The Angel and the Bitter-Sweet Scroll

Before the seventh trumpet sounds, John experiences a dramatic interlude: an angel brings him a scroll and commands him to eat it (Revelation 10:9-10). The scroll John eats is both sweet and bitter because it symbolizes the dual "bitter sweet" nature of the scroll's message—the hope of His promises and the coming of His Kingdom (symbolized by the sweet taste), but also the sorrow of suffering, persecution, and tribulation that must take place first (symbolized by bitterness). This echoes Ezekiel 2:8-3:3, where the prophet eats a scroll that is sweet like honey but carries a heavy message of lament and woe. John, like Ezekiel, is being commissioned as a prophet of both bad and good news, calling humanity to repentance, warning the oppressive powers with judgment, and giving hope to the faithful.

The Measuring of the Temple: Who Are the True Worshipers?

John's vision unfolds in two symbolic scenes, revealing the deeper meaning of God's unfolding plan. First, he is commanded to measure God’s temple, where the martyrs stand near the altar, set apart and protected (Revelation 11:1). This imagery is drawn from Zechariah 2:1-5, where measuring the city symbolizes divine protection. However, the outer courts and the city are left exposed to be trampled by the nations, a striking contrast that again symbolizes both suffering and hope.

Some interpret this as a literal destruction of Jerusalem, either in the past or the future, but a closer look at biblical symbolism suggests something deeper. The New Testament consistently teaches that God’s true temple is not a building but His people:

Do you not know that you are God's temple?

1 Corinthians 3:16

We are His house if we hold firmly to our confidence and hope.

Hebrews 3:6

You, like living stones, are being built into a spiritual house.

1 Peter 2:4-5

The measuring of the temple, then, represents God's spiritual blessings of His faithful ones, even amid persecution. Followers of Jesus may be oppressed, imprisoned, or even killed, yet those who stay faithful will turn to "pillars" in God's Kingdom.

Empires rise and fall, their magnificent structures crumble, but the faithful endure because God's temple is not made of stone but built from the souls of those who belong to Him. This is why Jesus declares, *"The one who conquers, I will make a pillar in the temple of my God"* (Revelation 3:12). In the world's eyes, they may seem weak, persecuted, and forgotten, but in reality, they are pillars of God's eternal Kingdom, honored for their sacrificial and unconditional love.

Jesus never promised His followers a life free from tribulation; in fact, He guaranteed the opposite: *"If they persecuted Me, they will also persecute you"* (John 15:20). Faithfulness to Christ often means facing rejection, hardship, and even martyrdom, yet this is not defeat but victory. The Lamb's people conquer not by force but through unwavering devotion, even in suffering.

The Two Witnesses: Prophets of the Lamb

John's vision continues with a second symbolic scene—the appointment of "two witnesses" (Revelation 11:3). Many have speculated about their identity, with some

interpreting them as two literal end-times prophets who one day will appear with superpowers (e.g., *"fire comes from their mouths and devours their enemies."* Revelation 11:5). But John gives us a major clue about their symbolic nature: he calls them "lampstands" (Revelation 11:4). And if we let Scripture interpret Scripture, we already know what lampstands represent—the people of God (Revelation 1:20).

This aligns with Jesus' own words in the Gospels. In Matthew 5:14-16, He calls His followers *"the light of the world,"* commanding them to let their light shine before others. A lamp is not meant to be hidden, but placed on a stand so that it can illuminate the darkness. In the ancient Tabernacle and Temple, the lampstand (Menorah) was a central symbol of God's presence and His people's mission to be a light to the nations (Exodus 25:31-40, Isaiah 42:6). John is building on this rich symbolic tradition, showing that the two witnesses represent God's ambassadors, who bear witness to God's truth in a hostile world.

The two witnesses most likely symbolize Moses and Elijah, who represent the Law and the Prophets. These two figures appeared alongside Jesus at the Transfiguration (Matthew 17:3), testifying that He is the fulfillment of everything the Law and the Prophets pointed to (Luke 24:27). Throughout Jewish tradition, Moses was the ultimate lawgiver and Elijah was the prototype of the fiery, miracle-working prophet who called Israel back to God (1 Kings 18:20-40). Together, they embody God's revelation—the Torah and the Prophets—and their role was always the same: to call Israel and the nations to repentance.

Like Moses and Elijah, the two witnesses in Revelation 11 perform miraculous signs that echo the powerful deeds of these Old Testament prophets. Just as Elijah called down fire from heaven to defeat his enemies (2 Kings 1:10-12) and stopped the rain for three and a half years (1 Kings 17:1), the two witnesses also summon fire against their adversaries and have authority to halt the rain (Revelation 11:5-6). Similarly, Moses demonstrated God's power by turning water into blood and striking Egypt with various plagues (Exodus 7–11), paralleling the witnesses' ability to unleash plagues on the earth (Revelation 11:6). These two witnesses face persecution, are killed by the beast (representing the oppressive empire), but are dramatically vindicated when, just like Jesus's resurrection after three and a half days, God resurrects them after three and a half days, demonstrating His power publicly before the nations (Revelation 11:7-12).

In a sense, the Book of Revelation presents a powerful metamorphosis — the narrative of Moses and Elijah (the Old Testament) transforms into the narrative of Jesus, and the fulfillment of all things (the New Testament). It's not a rejection of what came before, but a revelation of how the story finds its climax in the person of Yeshua — where law and prophecy converge into love, sacrifice, and redemption.

Now, this dramatic turn of events — the resurrection — leads to an astonishing outcome: many among the nations **do finally repent** and give honor to the Creator God (Revelation 11:13). In other words, the nations repented because God showed them His grace!

Despite the beast's attempt to silence the witnesses — not just Moses (Law), Elijah (Prophets) and Jesus (New Testament), but of all times — God's testimony prevails. This beautifully encapsulates Revelation's message: that evil—often represented by oppressive empires—always seeks to resist good, but in the end, God's goodness will prevail.

The Two Witnesses Throughout History

History confirms this pattern: The nations couldn't destroy God's Chosen People and their message. Later, Jesus' message couldn't be stopped despite killing Him. Then, the early Roman persecution of Christians did not destroy the faith—it accelerated its growth. The very attempt to behead Christianity only caused it to spread faster. As believers fled persecution, they carried the gospel to new lands, and in the centuries that followed, Christianity became a global movement. The Roman Empire, the same beastly power that sought to crush it, ultimately caused its spread and fell to the very message it tried to eliminate.

This is the paradox of Revelation's message: evil may seem to triumph for a time, but faithfulness and sacrificial love ultimately conquer. What Satan and the beast tried to destroy, persecute and crucify, God turns into an explosion of grace and redemption. The blood of the martyrs truly is the seed of the Church!

Thus, the two witnesses mirror the pattern of faithful witnesses throughout history, but especially of Israel's prophets (including Jesus and His disciples), who brought God's message yet were rejected, persecuted, killed, and then glorified. Their mission, miraculous powers, suffering, and vindication all reinforce Revelation's central

message: true victory is not won by the sword, but through endurance, sacrificial love, and faithfulness to God's justice. The forces of evil always try to silence the truth, but even death cannot stop the message and mission of divine Grace.

The Seventh Trumpet: The Kingdom Has Come

Finally, the seventh trumpet sounds, and a powerful declaration is made,

> *The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of His Messiah, and He will reign forever and ever.*
>
> Revelation 11:15

Did you catch that? **The last judgement and God's victory is not the destruction of the world, but its transformation!** The kingdoms of the earth finally become God's kingdom: *"As surely as I live, says the Lord, every knee will bow before Me; every tongue will confess to God."* (Romans 14:11). This is not just about a future event—it is a process already underway. Every time someone turns to Christ, every time injustice is confronted, every time love triumphs over hatred, every time a sinner is being forgiven—God's Kingdom is advancing!

Conclusion: The Victory of the Lamb is Through Sacrificial Love

The pattern in Revelation is clear: judgment, while needed, does not change hearts, but sacrificial love does. The nations did not repent when the plagues came, but when they saw the faithful witness of the martyrs, many turned to God (Revelation 11:13).

This is the heart of the Gospel:

- The Law is good, but judgment cannot produce true righteousness.
- The Lamb's triumph, born from sacrificial love, leads to righteousness.
- The world is not to be won by force, fear, or domination, but by faithful endurance and God's grace.

That is why the Gospel spread so rapidly in the ancient church and in persecuted countries today. The Roman Empire could not destroy Christianity, despite executing its leaders. In fact, persecution only led to more people coming to faith because they witnessed in the martyrs a kind of love and devotion that the world could not offer—self-sacrificial, unwavering, and saturated with goodness, refusing to retaliate with violence even in the face of death.

Revelation 8-11 reveals the stark contrast between how the world operates and how God's kingdom does:

- Oppressive empires try to conquer through the beastly power of oppression and violence.
- God conquers hearts through love, forgiveness, and endurance.

The two witnesses represent the mission of the Church—to stand as a testimony to God's truth, even when it costs us everything. The final trumpet reminds us that the kingdoms of this world will not last, but God's kingdom will reign forever.

The question Revelation presents is not *"How can we escape suffering?"* but *"Will we remain faithful in the midst of tribulation?"*

Revelation 12: The Dragon, the Woman, and Her Child

After exploring the surprising message of the Lamb's opened scroll, John presents a series of seven visions, which he refers to as signs (Revelation 12-15). The Greek word for "sign" (*sēmeion*) means symbol, further emphasizing the symbolic nature of Revelation. The purpose of Revelation's symbolic visions is to expand further on the message of the Lamb's scroll, unveiling the cosmic battle between God's kingdom and the forces of darkness.

The Cosmic War and the Woman's Offspring

The first sign or symbol reveals the hidden spiritual conflict behind the persecution of Christians in the Roman Empire, tracing its roots all the way back to Genesis 3:15, where God declares enmity between the "serpent" and the offspring of the woman. The Garden of Eden's *NACHASH* (often translated "serpent," but more accurately meaning *a reptile-looking angelic being shining like copper/brass*[19]), and the master of evil is now more clearly depicted as a great red dragon (Revelation 12:3). This *NACHASH*, or red dragon, represents evil itself, standing in opposition to God's people throughout history.

The Woman, Her Child, and the Dragon

John's vision introduces a **woman** clothed with the sun, standing on the moon, and crowned with twelve stars (Revelation 12:1). Who is she? The imagery draws heavily from Joseph's dream in Genesis 37:9, where the sun, moon, and twelve stars represent the twelve tribes of Israel. This suggests that the woman primarily represents the **nation of Israel**, through whom the child (the Jewish the Messiah) was born.

Then, in verse 5, the woman (Israel) gives birth to a male child (Christ), whom John identifies as the one who will rule the nations with a rod of iron (Revelation 12:5). In ancient biblical Judaism, a rod symbolized authoritative leadership (Psalms 23:4), while iron represented strength and permanence—something unbreakable and enduring (unlike the more common wooden rods). This is a direct reference to Psalm 2 (especially verse 9), which describes the Messiah's authority over the nations.

The dragon (Satan) immediately seeks to devour the woman's child (Christ), paralleling Herod's attempt to kill Jesus as an infant (Matthew 2:16). However, the child in John's vision is ultimately *"snatched up to God and to his throne"* (verse 5).

Recap: The woman (Israel), gives birth to the child (Christ), who is opposed by the dragon (Satan).

Then, *"the woman fled into the wilderness to a place prepared for her by God, where she might be taken care of for 1,260 days"* (Revelation 12:6). This echoes:

1. Israel's Exodus experience in the Egyptian wilderness, and 1,260 days echoes Daniel's prophecies (e.g., Daniel 7:25; 12:7).
2. Joseph and Mary fleeing to the Egyptian wilderness (Matthew 2:13) for, likely, 1,260 days (three and a half years).
3. The flight of the first church of Jewish-Christians from Jerusalem during the Jewish war against Rome (around 66-70 AD). Before the destruction of the Temple, many Jewish believers, heeding Jesus' warning (*"Then let those who are in Judea flee to the mountains"*—Matthew 24:16), reportedly escaped to Pella, a city in the Decapolis, where they found refuge. This also aligns with the woman (Israel) fleeing into the wilderness for divine protection. Here, however, the woman symbolizes not only Israel but both Jewish believers in Christ and the gentile believers who joined in (Acts 15:12-15).

1,260 Days = 42 months = 3.5 years

The 3.5 years (also described as 1,260 days or 42 months) is a theme — a recurring symbolic period (based on the 360-day Jewish year multiplied by 3.5) in apocalyptic literature.[20] Rather than being tied to just one historical event, this 1,260-day period is a recurring biblical pattern. For instance:

- **Elijah's drought lasted 3.5 years (1 Kings 17:1, Luke 4:25).**
- **The second half of Daniel's 70th week (Daniel 9:27) lasts 3.5 years.**
- **The two witnesses prophesy for 1,260 days (Revelation 11:3).**
- **The woman flees into the wilderness for 1,260 days (Revelation 12:6)**
- **The Beast is given authority for 42 months (Revelation 13:5).**

The Divided Seven (Completion vs. Incompleteness)

The Bible frequently uses the number seven to symbolize divine completion (e.g., the week of creation). Half of seven—3.5—often represents something unfinished, interrupted, or in a state of trial before ultimate resolution. This is why 3.5 years often appear as a period of tribulation, waiting, or struggle before deliverance.

The Persecution of "the Woman" Persists.

Unable to destroy the Messiah, the dragon then pursues the woman. But she is given wings and escapes into the wilderness (Revelation 12:14), reminiscent of how God carried Israel *"on eagles' wings"* out of Egypt (Exodus 19:4).

Both the Jews in Israel and the early Church throughout the Roman empire experienced waves of intense persecution. Seen as a subversive movement refusing to worship the emperor, Jews and Christians were hunted, imprisoned, and executed. Many were forced underground, meeting in secret (such as in the catacombs of Rome), or fleeing Rome's aggressive oppression.

Thus, the imagery of the woman in the wilderness reflects a **theme**: Israel's physical flight from Egypt, Christ's escape from Herod, the early Jewish believers' departure prior to the destruction of Jerusalem, and the Church's endurance under persecution ever since.

This 3.5-year duration possibly symbolizes the era between Jesus' ascension and His anticipated return—a time characterized by the Church's prophetic witness amidst opposition; An age in which believers testify to the gospel amid trials while awaiting Christ's return.

The War in Heaven and the Dragon's Defeat

The next vision shows a great battle in heaven: Michael and his angels against the

dragon and his fallen angels (Revelation 12:7-9). Michael, the archangel, appears in Daniel 10:13 and Daniel 12:1 as the protector of God's people Israel. Then, the dragon is cast down to Earth, losing his place in heaven.

What does this mean? It could refer to Satan's original rebellion, to his defeat through Jesus' death and resurrection, or both. Jesus spoke of Satan metaphorically falling *"like lightning from heaven"* (Luke 10:18), showing that the cross was the turning point in the cosmic war. Satan no longer has the right to accuse people, as Christ's blood has justified them (Revelation 12:10-11).

However, being cast down does not mean Satan dies or stops fighting. Instead, he turns his fury against God's people on Earth. He knows his time is short (Revelation 12:12), and in desperation, he continues his work of deceiving people and using them for the persecution of God's people.

Here, however, we must remind ourselves that *"our battle is not against flesh and blood but against dark spiritual powers"* (Ephesians 6:12). These spiritual powers, brainwashing people's minds, work through them, turning them into enemies of God—wicked evildoers. That's why we are called to love them—our enemies—because they are not truly our enemies; they have been deceived and indoctrinated with hate and the best way to resist hate is not by multiplying hate but by conquering it with love. Otherwise, if we respond to hate with more hate, it only fuels an endless cycle of retaliation—exactly what Satan desires!

Recap

1. The **woman** is Israel, giving birth to the Messiah.
2. The **child** is Jesus, caught up to God's throne.
3. The **woman's offspring** now includes the church (**all believers in Christ**, both Jewish and Gentile).
4. The **dragon wages war against them**, just as he has always done against God's people.

Then, John describes a river spewed from the dragon's mouth, attempting to sweep the woman away (Revelation 12:15). This could symbolize false teachings, persecution, or deception, all tactics Satan has historically used to destroy God's people. Yet, the earth helps the woman by swallowing the river, echoing the way God opened the earth to swallow the rebellion of Korah (Numbers 16:32). The earth swallowing the river symbolizes God's intervention—whether through divine protection, historical events, or unforeseen circumstances—that prevents Satan's attempts to stop God's plan.

Victory Through the Blood of the Lamb

In verse 11, John makes a crucial statement:

> *They conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they did not love their lives even unto death.*
>
> Revelation 12:11

In biblical tradition, blood holds profound significance as it embodies life itself. Leviticus 17:11 emphasizes this by stating, *"For the life of a creature is in the blood."* Consequently, blood was central to purification and atonement rituals, acting as a spiritual cleanser that purified the sanctuary and the people of Israel from their sin.[21] This symbolism is fulfilled in the New Testament, where Jesus' sacrificial blood is portrayed as the ultimate means of purification and redemption, reversing the effect of sin—death—and offering immortal life instead.

How, according to John, do believers overcome Satan? By following the way of the Lamb—not through military might or political power, but through sacrificial faithfulness. This is not a statement against Christians participating in political or military affairs; rather, it concerns the attitude, motivation, values, and focus of Christians themselves.

Jesus' victory over His enemies, achieved through the gift of His life (blood), compels His true followers to emulate His self-sacrificing spirit and follow in His footsteps.

The end of verse 11 (*"Did not love their lives")* can sound confusing, but it simply means they prioritized faithfulness to Christ over self-preservation, even to the point of facing death rather than denying Him — martyrs.

Conclusion: The Real Enemy

The seven churches to whom John writes are facing intense persecution, oppression, and hardship, struggling under the weight of beastly human empires. Yet, John lovingly reminds them—and us—that the Messiah has already triumphed, and that our ultimate hope and victory rest securely in Him. Though the dragon's power may be real, it is both limited and temporary. John's profound vision in Revelation 12 opens our eyes to see that our battle is not against the people of Rome, Babylon, or members of any human empire, but rather against the unseen spiritual forces of evil working behind and through them. Therefore, we are encouraged to remain faithful and courageous even through persecution, to resist the temptation toward endless retaliation, and to persevere with confidence, knowing the final victory is already assured through Christ.

Revelation 13: The Two Beasts

John's next vision in Revelation 13 revisits the cosmic conflict, this time using the symbolism of Daniel's apocalyptic visions (Daniel 7-12). He describes two beasts, both serving the dragon (Satan), representing the two major forces of evil. These beasts are the instruments of Satan's ultimate attempt to deceive the world and claim the worship that belongs to God alone.

A "beast" symbolizes aggression, violence and oppressive. It stands for anti-God powers, typically representing corrupt empires, institutions, or rulers who oppose God's authority, persecute believers, and demand absolute allegiance. Revelation intentionally uses the vivid imagery of a beast—ferocious, monstrous, and chaotic—to highlight the destructive, subhuman nature of these evil forces. By portraying these powers as beasts rather than humans, Revelation emphasizes their spiritual corruption, violence, and rebellion against God, warning believers against complicity and encouraging faithful endurance until God's ultimate victory.

The "Antichrist"

In certain evangelical circles, the first beast is the one often labelled as "the Antichrist."

However, and this might come as a shock to some, the term "antichrist" does not actually appear anywhere in this chapter nor anywhere else in the Book of Revelation.

But John writes about it elsewhere. In 1 John, the author writes that *"Even now **many** antichrists have come"* (1 John 2:18) and that *"**Whoever** denies the Father and the Son, this is the antichrist."* (1 John 2:22). To John, the term *antichrist* clearly signified a spirit in people that is opposed to that of Christ, and not a specific figure from the far future.

Yes. According to John himself, the antichrist is not a "he" (a specific person) but an "it" (a spirit) — a posture of resistance, from within the church, to a specific truth:

> *Hereby know ye the Spirit of God: Every spirit that confesseth that Jesus Christ is **come in the flesh** is of God: And every spirit that confesseth not that Jesus Christ is **come in the flesh** is not of God: and this is that **spirit of antichrist**, whereof ye have heard that **it** should come; and even now already is **it** in the world.*
>
> (1 John 4:2–3, KJV)

It, not *him*. A specific truth denied — that Jesus came in the FLESH.

I had to quote from a very old version — the 1611 Anglican King James Version — because ironically, the Protestants removed the word "flesh" from verse 3 in their most popular versions (NIV, ESV, NASB, ASV, ERV, ISV, NET, etc.).

Likewise, in his other letter, 2 John 1:7, he writes: *"**Many** deceivers, who do not acknowledge Jesus Christ as coming in the **flesh**, have gone out into the world. **Any such person** is the deceiver and the **antichrist**."*

To sum up, the term *antichrist* in the Bible is never used to describe a singular, future political or religious figure. Instead, it refers exclusively to a spirit. Spirit, meaning it's not a tangible or physical manifestation, but an idea, belief, or mindset

of deception and resistance to the true identity of Jesus — which, according to John, was already at work in his day and manifested through many false teachers.

Why is "Flesh" Crucial?

Bear in mind that John had also recently written a letter combating Gnosticism (1 John), which is the idea that through esoteric knowledge (gnosis) we enable the Spirit to redeem our human spirit.

Ironically, two thousand years later, many of us still believe that intellectual knowledge, like reciting a line of a pamphlet, affirming the correct doctrine, or adhering to the right creed, can save a person. This is, at its core, the very essence of Gnosticism.

Ancient Gnostics believed salvation came through gnosis — divine knowledge that "enlightened" the soul. Similarly, many modern Western gospel presentations that teach people are saved or damned based on what they mentally understand reduces the Gospel to a cerebral exam. It's the same fleshless gospel — repackaged Gnosticism disguised as Christianity.

Biblical faith was never about intellectual formulas, but about hearts transformed to better love others.

Modern-Day Gnosticism

What creed you affirm or theology you follow will shape how you represent Christ to the world. Knowing what you believe matters — but above all, Scripture tells us that love is what matters most (1 Peter 4:8; 1 Corinthians 13:13). True faith must be expressed through love, and love is not merely an abstract — it is a verb. It takes action. It gives. It sacrifices.

If faith is reduced to an intellectual possession — something you simply agree with mentally — then James poses a piercing question: *"What good is it, my brothers and sisters, if someone claims to have faith but has no deeds?... Suppose a brother or sister is without clothes and daily food... faith by itself, if it does not result in action, is dead."* (James 2:14–17).

Blessing the poor and needy with doctrine means little if it's not accompanied by sacrificial love. The kind of faith that God desires is not just recited — it's revealed in how we treat the hungry, the hurting, and the forgotten. Because in the end, the only faith that truly lives is the one that loves.

Likewise, the spirit of the antichrist is any teaching or influence that denies the incarnational reality of Jesus — that God came near, in the flesh, as a human. John isn't warning about some future tyrant with horns. He's warning about a present, active, crucial theological distortion of Jesus' identity and mission — already at work in the first century.

Contrast this with today's popular end-times theories, which portray the Antichrist as a singular, evil political leader who will rise to power. Ironically, this fixation on an imaginary future villain distracts from the real danger John was pointing to: the subtle, theological erosion of Jesus' humanity.

See, you don't have to become a gnostic to ignore Jesus' incarnation, you can just turn Him from a person to theology. Reducing Christ to a doctrine in "systematic theology" diminishes how He lived in the flesh every single day and the example He set for us in His flesh — loving others sacrificially.

John abhorred Gnosticism so deeply because he recognized how it hollowed out the heart of the gospel. It reduced salvation to a private theory — an esoteric knowledge one must intellectually affirm to escape judgment. In this distorted view, the gospel became a mental transaction: believe the right idea, check the right box, and you're off the hook.

But John knew better. He had walked with Jesus, touched Him, heard His voice, seen His compassion. He knew the gospel wasn't just a set of ideas — it was embodied truth. It was relational. It was incarnational. And he understood that when faith becomes nothing more than intellectual assent, it leaves the door wide open for deception.

That's precisely where the Second Beast — the counterfeit religion — thrives. It doesn't oppose religion; it embraces a neutered, disembodied version of it. One that looks like a lamb but speaks like a dragon. One that replaces living faith with dead theory. One that sounds biblical but smells of the antichrist spirit — the spirit that ignores the crucial aspect of Christ in the flesh.

The spirit of the antichrist doesn't need to burn churches. It just needs to reduce Jesus to an abstract. Because a theoretical Christ doesn't change lives. Only the living One does.

Some Western Denominations Overlooked John's Warnings

When Jesus becomes a set of doctrines to study in a Bible College — a theology to adhere to, a doctrinal thesis to memorize, or a formula to pray from a pamphlet — He is stripped of His relational power. His life becomes a set of propositions to be mentally affirmed (as if we impress God by our intellectual and theological knowledge), rather than a truth to be lived. This reduces the gospel to a kind of intellectual exam one must pass to be "saved."

But if Jesus truly came in flesh, lived, felt, healed, loved, forgave, and laid down His life for His enemies — then His existence is not only to be believed, but a living example to be embodied. Following Jesus is not about subscribing to a religious party but about living like Him: forgiving instead of retaliating, loving your enemies, showing mercy to the poor and outcast, and walking in humility.

Theoretical ideas about Jesus — "Christology," — can be debated and revised to differentiate between who is "in" and who is "out." You can be a Christian who believes all the "right" creeds and never misses a Sunday class — and still not reflect Christ's life in your own life. When Jesus becomes “Systematic Theology,” we stop imitating Him—and start replacing Him with doctrines about Him. That’s the work of the antichrist spirit.

The antichrist spirit doesn’t show up wearing a suit and waving a red flag. It shows up subtly, through teachings that reduce flesh to a theory, distort His message, and strip the gospel of its love.

So, if not through a theology exam, how did they differentiate between someone who is a true Christian and someone who's not? Let’s just put it this way: from verses 7 to 21 of the same chapter, the word *"love"* pops up 27 times. John's answer is that a true follower of God loves others sacrificially. If you’re up for diving deeper into that rabbit hole with me, check out my book, ***The "Theology" of Love: Christianity's Most Underrated Doctrine.***

Back to Revelation. The early church's battle wasn't against future politicians — it was against false images of God within the church that led people away from loving others through the power and example of living Messiah and into counterfeit religion. A religion that looks like the lamb on the outside — on paper, doctrine, and creed — but underneath, it's actually a wolf. A dragon. A whitewashed tomb. An antichrist. A religion that cloaks like Jesus but is actually fake.

Having said that, the recurring, cyclical nature of these antichrists doesn't rule out the possibility of a final, ultimate one. It's similar to how in video games, players may face multiple "bosses" throughout the game, each presenting a significant challenge, but eventually, there is one final, exceptionally powerful boss who surpasses all the previous ones — A terrible Beast.

The First Beast — Empires of Economic and Military Power

Revelation 13 begins with John's vision, seeing a beast rising out of the sea, having **ten horns** and **seven heads**, with the mouth of a **lion**, feet of a **bear**, and body of a **leopard** (Revelation 13:1-2). Let's dissect this beast in our theological lab:

- **Ten Horns**

The beast's **ten horns** (see Daniel 7:24) symbolize ten rulers and kings (Revelation 17:12), as explicitly explained in Revelation 17:12, where it states, *"The ten horns you saw are ten kings who have not yet received a kingdom..."* — clearly identifying these horns as **political powers** that influence the global stage.

- **Seven Heads**

The **seven heads** are explicitly said to be "seven hills" (Revelation 17:9), a clear allusion to the powerful empire of Rome, known as *the city of seven hills*. These seven hills located east of the Tiber River are considered the grounds where Rome was founded; they are an integral part of Rome's historical and cultural landscape. The seven hills of Rome are Palatine Hill, Aventine Hill, Capitoline Hill, Caelian Hill, Esquiline Hill, Viminal Hill and Quirinal Hill.

Thus, the beast's **seven heads** symbolize the Roman empire — and any other oppressive empire since.

Empires aren't inherently evil — they're simply large structures of governance. What determines their nature is who or what stands behind them. An empire can serve as a force for good, administering justice and showing kindness to its subjects. But it can just as easily become a tool of oppression, fueled by greed, pride, and domination. It's not the size of the structure that defines its morality — it's the spirit that animates it.

Lion's Mouth, Bear's Feat, Leopard's Body

The imagery of the **lion**, **bear**, and **leopard**, taken from Daniel 7, where four beasts emerge from the sea, symbolizes successive world empires known for their power and domination: the **lion** represents Babylon's majesty and authority, the **bear** symbolizes Medo-Persia's strength and aggression, and the **leopard** portrays Greece's swift and expansive conquests. By combining these beasts into one beast, Revelation shows that its beast is a fusion or culmination of oppressive empires, illustrating a recurring system of corrupt, violent, and beastly rule that persists throughout history.

The Dragon Controls the Beast

The beast (oppressive empires) receives its power from the dragon (Satan) and exercises authority over all nations (Revelation 13:4-5). One of its heads appears to be fatally wounded but is healed, causing the world to marvel and follow it. The fatal wound that is healed (Revelation 13:3) symbolizes how oppressive empires—though they seem to collapse—always rise again in new forms (somewhat like the mythological Lernaean hydra). While it could also reference Rome's resilience after Nero's death (with rumors of his return), more broadly, it represents the recurring pattern of fallen regimes being replaced by new oppressive powers throughout history.

Throughout history, human rulers and empires have turned into beasts when they demand ultimate allegiance, claim divine status, or rule through offensive conquest and oppression.

Historically, in the Roman Empire, loyalty to the emperor was enforced through economic control, which is why *"no one could buy or sell anything without that mark, which was either the name of the beast or the number representing his name."* (Revelation 13:16-17). Now, guess what? Ancient Roman coins bore the image and name — the mark — of the Roman Caesar—including Nero and Domitian—the very ones the beast in this apocalyptic symbolism represented.

But history has a way of repeating itself. The beast may change faces, but the oppressive systems of control, idolatry, and economic allegiance remain hauntingly familiar, and will continue to be with us until the Lord returns.

Worshipping Caesar—the Beast—as God

Citizens and merchants had to offer not only taxation but also incense to Caesar as a god, and those who refused could face exclusion from trade, imprisonment, or death. The word for "mark" (*charagma*) also refers to official seals on documents, making them legal.[22] This suggests that without them, one couldn't buy or sell in the markets.

Thus, John is warning his readers that the "beast" does not only rule through violence but also through economic coercion.

Paying taxes to Caesar was considered acceptable by early Christians because supporting a government — even one they may have deeply opposed — acknowledged a greater principle: that earthly authorities, despite their flaws, have a God-given responsibility to maintain order, protect society, and restrain wrongdoing.

This was a reality well understood by Jesus' Jewish disciples, who lived in Israel under the oppressive rule of Rome. Submitting to civil structures wasn't an endorsement of tyranny, but a recognition that some form of governance is necessary for the functioning of human society — even as ultimate allegiance remains with God.

However, offering worship to Caesar was not acceptable, because worship belongs to God alone. Jesus' statement, *"Give to Caesar what is Caesar's [taxes], and to God what is God's [worship]"* (Matthew 22:21), was a bold declaration that allegiance to earthly rulers has limits. To worship a human ruler — or the corruption they stand for — is idolatry. A refusal to worship, even if it means being banned from the marketplace, is the only righteous choice.

Regardless, Rome was the beast of Jesus' and John's day, but Babylon, Egypt, Assyria, or any other power-hungry empire had also played the same role. And, as history has shown, the beast continues to appear in new forms, with different faces, but with the same oppressive hunger for power and wealth.

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The Second Beast: Knockoff Jesus and Religious Manipulation

Then, John sees a second beast, rising from the earth (Revelation 13:11-12). Unlike the first beast, this one appears *"like a lamb but spoke like a dragon."* A lamb symbolizes something pure and innocent. But in the Book of Revelation (and John's other writings), the lamb always stands for the innocent lamb of God—Christ.[23] This deceptive image suggests false religion and ideological manipulation masquerades as Christian, which totally makes sense as a demonic tactic, when considering that *"even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light"* (2 Corinthians 11:14).

Since it looks like Jesus (lamb) but is actually Satan (the dragon), it should be seen as a religion that falsely represents Jesus. The second beast doesn't eliminate religion—it manipulates and exploits it. With it, it becomes an even stronger oppressive empire using faith as a tool to control, deceive, and justify its pursuit of power, wealth, and domination (aligning with the first beast).

The second beast represents not genuine Christian faith but a counterfeit—any religious denomination that claims Christ, calls itself Christian, and professes Jesus as "Lord," yet ultimately faces His rebuke: *"I never knew* [had intimacy with or approved of] *you. Away from me, you evildoers!"* (Matthew 7:23).

The Theological Implication

I'm not saying this as a politician, but as a theologian: if there's one thing the second beast loves, it's the merging of church and state. Because when that happens — when religion unites with corrupt politicians — it inevitably evolves into an oppressive empire, as proven by history.

Every empire becomes beastly when it merges with religion — even when that religion is Christianity. That's precisely why John warns us in Revelation that the dragon doesn't always appear as something obviously evil. Sometimes, it disguises

itself as a lamb — a symbol of Christ — while speaking with the voice of the dragon (Revelation 13:11).

In other words, the most dangerous form of deception isn't open persecution, but counterfeit faith. When empire wraps itself in Christian language and symbols, it no longer serves the kingdom of God — it serves power, control, and domination in His name. We saw it with Nazi Germany, which was Protestant. We saw it with the British empire, which was Anglican. We saw it with Spain, which was Catholic.[24] We saw it with the Byzantine Empire, which was Eastern Christian. We see it now with Russia, which is predominantly Proto-Slavic Orthodox. And I hope we won't come to see it in America.

Christian Imperialism?

We also saw it with Rome under Constantine the Great, when the early Jesus movement was absorbed into imperial power. What followed was centuries of institutional religion entangled with political corruption and controlled by it.

I hope future Christian denominations will reflect on history — and the warnings in the Book of Revelation — and resist the temptation to repeat the same mistakes. When faith is fused with state power, it often ceases to be prophetic and turns political and imperial. And that's exactly what the second beast desires and how it thrives.

The second beast, appearing like a lamb, reveals that there are two distinct forms of "Christianity." The first is a religion primarily driven by moralism, intellectually committed to doctrinal statements about Jesus' Lordship, and typically holding traditional creeds as sacred. However, it often seeks to control, thus influenced by a desire for political power.

In contrast, the second form embodies the kingdom of heaven—a way of life demonstrated by Christ-like individuals who actively practice the values Jesus lived and taught. These include loving-kindness, empathy, justice, compassion, grace, forgiveness, humility, and selflessness. Rather than merely affirming doctrines intellectually, authentic Christianity transforms a person's worldview, values, relationships, and actions, genuinely reflecting the heart and character of Jesus. Individuals, rather than religious systems, often demonstrate this form of Christianity.

Thus, if the first beast represents military and political power, the second beast could represent propaganda and religious deception. It performs "great signs" and deceives people into worshiping the first beast (imperialism and military power).

Constantine the Great

With the fusion of Christianity with imperial power in the 4th century during the reign of Constantine the Great (306–337 AD), Christianity began its transition to becoming the dominant religion of the Roman Empire. Constantine ruled as sole emperor for much of his reign, and some scholars suggest that his primary objective was to secure unanimous approval and submission to his authority across all social classes. To achieve this, he allegedly adopted Christianity as a tool for political propaganda, believing it to be the most suitable religion to align with the Roman Imperial Cult. Whether Constantine genuinely converted to Christianity or remained loyal to paganism [25] remains a subject of debate among historians. What's even more confusing is his refusal to be baptised in Christ's name until only very shortly before his death.

Until the First Council of Nicaea (325 AD), all previous Church councils had been local or regional synods that affected only parts of the Christian community. Nicaea, however, was Constantine's successful attempt to coerce, redefine, and control orthodoxy for both the state and the Church. I'm using "redefine" because the Didache —the theological creed of Jesus' apostles—was very different from that of Nicaea.

Moreover, Constantine worked to create a "Jewish-free" religion—removing Jewish leaders, negating Jewish feasts, promoting new doctrines, and even banning Christian Jews from participation in the council. His infamous words, *"Let us then have nothing in common with the detestable Jewish crowd",* well illustrate the shift, the lasting effects on Christian-Jewish relations and on later Christian interpretation of the Bible, especially on the rise of the new Augustinian theology. [26]

Jews Out—Neo Platonism In

The deliberate exclusion of theologians who were Jewish believers in Jesus and

rejecting anything with Jewish roots effectively transformed Christianity into a new power-driven religion that was based on the state and largely disconnected from its original spiritual foundations.

While Constantine's legalization of Christianity ended Roman persecution, it also transformed the faith into a tool of the state. Christianity, once a movement of sacrificial love and radical allegiance to Christ, became entangled with political authority, military conquest, and wealth. Bishops gained political power and wealth, church leaders were given state-sponsored privileges, and Christianity was soon used to justify imperial expansion.

But this was not a one-time incident—it was a warning for every generation. Since Constantine, many religious systems have claimed Christ's name while serving the interests of the first beast—power, hyper-nationalism, and material gain. The Crusades turned faith into warfare. The medieval church amassed immense wealth while the poor suffered and whoever stood against it had to face the Church's inquisitions. Nazi Germany co-opted Christianity, blending it with Aryan nationalism to justify unspeakable atrocities. Even today, Christian groups and individuals take advantage of faith for monetary profit, and individuals and movements involved with politics frequently manipulate faith to further their own objectives, rather than truly promoting the Kingdom of God. This, of course, is true not only with Christianity but also in other religions.

John's vision warns us that the greatest threat to true faith is not external persecution but internal corruption—when Christianity stops looking like the slain Lamb and instead resembles the beasts it was meant to resist.

And it has serious, long-lasting effects on the Gospel, too.

Take India, for example. The leadership of the British Empire was almost exclusively Christian, and behind the scenes, Christianity played a significant role in shaping the empire and its vision. India was under British oppressive occupation for nearly two centuries — and while colonial rule isn't in itself evil, the British Empire was often tyrannical, violent, and merciless in its treatment of native populations.

Now, ask yourself: what impression did that leave in the minds of the many millions of Indians about what Christianity represents? When the "Christian empire" ruled them with injustice, how would the average Indian — like those raised in Hinduism — come to view the Christian God? Likely not as a God of mercy, compassion, and

love. Would they then want to follow that Western religion? I think not. Not when it's oppressing the weak, poor and needy, instead of protecting them.

The Beasts That Killed Jesus

It is often said that "our sin killed Jesus." While there is a measure of truth in this, such a statement oversimplifies and dilutes the rich complexity of the cross narrative. Jesus was not killed by some abstract concept of sin floating in the air — He was killed by a very specific kind of sin: the cooperation between the second beast (corrupt religion —e.g., represented by the priests and Pharisees) and the first beast (the oppressive Roman Empire). It was the religious establishment that handed Him over, and it was the Roman Empire that carried out His execution.

Jesus was rejected, abused, degraded, humiliated, tortured, and ultimately murdered — not by sinners in general, but by the toxic alliance of religious power and political empire working together to preserve control and crush what threatened their authority—the Lamb of God. It's no coincidence that these same forces — religion gone corrupt and empire gone violent — are symbolized as the two beasts in the Book of Revelation. The cross exposes not just human sin in theory but the real-world manifestation of sin through systems of power, control, and violence.

The Mark of the Beast

One of the most famous and debated symbols in Revelation is the Mark of the Beast—666 (Revelation 13:18), which is *"a mark on their right hands or on their foreheads"* (verse 16). John tells his readers that this is a number of a man (or humanity), and it calls for wisdom to understand it.

The Number 666

If in biblical symbolism seven is the number of divine perfection and completion,

six, falling just short of seven, often symbolizes incompleteness and the human limitation. Thus, 666 represents humanity's number, emphasizing imperfection and falling short of divine completion.

By repeating six three times (666), John intensifies this meaning, likely pointing to humanity at its worst—when people or systems elevate themselves as divine, seeking power, wealth, and control apart from God. It is the ultimate man-centered rule, where empires and leaders claim authority and honor that belong to God alone. This reinforces John's warning: when human rulers or institutions act as gods, demanding allegiance and controlling the world's systems, they embody the beast.

However, there's another layer to it…

Nero and the Pattern of Beastly Kings

It is no coincidence that John says that the number of the beast is 666 and invites his readers to calculate it (Revelation 13:18).



In Hebrew, letters also function as numbers (gematria).[27] The name "Nero Caesar" in Hebrew letters adds up to 666. This suggests that Nero, the brutal persecutor of Christians, was the "666" Revelation refers to, or at least uses as, the prime example.

Nero isn't necessarily the only fulfillment of this prophecy. I believe John is using Nero as an archetype of all leaders who act like Nero the Beast—those who seek absolute power, crush their enemies without mercy, and demand worship. Throughout history, we have seen leaders rise and fall, all repeating the same beastly pattern.

A Mark on the Right Hand or Forehead

The meaning of this dual symbol might not be obvious to most Christians, but to Jews, it was deeply rooted in both biblical and Hebrew thought. The mark of the beast is an inversion of the *Shema*. The *Shema Yisrael* (*"Hear, O Israel"*) is the central

declaration of Jewish faith, recited daily for thousands of years as an expression of absolute devotion to God's oneness and commandments, shaping Jewish identity, prayer, and life ever since the nation's exile from Egypt. The *Shema*, which became the most sacred Jewish prayer of allegiance to God in Judaism, is taken right from Deuteronomy:

> ***Hear, O Israel**: The Lord our God, the Lord is one. Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength... Tie them as symbols **on your hands** and bind them **on your foreheads**.*
>
> Deuteronomy 6:4-8

In Jewish tradition, *Tefillin* became the practice of physically attaching God's commandments on one's forehead (symbolizing our thoughts) and on one's hand (symbolizing our actions) as a way of expressing full devotion to God. The *Tefillin* are small black leather boxes containing Bible passages, worn on the arm and forehead during prayer, expressing the command in Deuteronomy 6:8 to bind His words as a sign on your hand and on your foreheads. Thus, the Tefillin symbolizes the alignment of a Jew's thought or mind (head) and action (hand) with God's will.

Historically, the earliest known *tefillin* cases and parchments were found among the Dead Sea Scrolls, proving that Jews in Jesus' time used them. This makes Revelation 13:16 especially relatable to John's Jewish audience and all the more striking in this context.

The Anti-Shema

In Revelation, both God (Revelation 7:3) and the beast (Revelation 13:16) demand the same total allegiance, similarly expressed through a mark on the forehead. But instead of devotion to the Creator, the beastly mark is in devotion to the empire and its ruler. Thus, to the original readers, the *"mark on their right hands or on their foreheads"* (verse 16) was not about a tattoo or microchip, but a symbol of who or what a person worships with their thoughts (forehead) and actions (hands).

Revelation 14-16: Judgment and Armageddon

Contrasting the dragon and the beasts, John now presents a vision of the true King—the Lamb—standing on Mount Zion (Revelation 14:1). With Him are 144,000 "virgins" (verse 4), not literal celibates, but a symbol of spiritual purity. They represent faithful followers who have remained loyal to God and untainted by the corruption of Babylon.

This imagery serves as a stark contrast to the previous chapter, where the world was deceived into worshiping the beast. Here, however, we see a remnant of God's people who have refused to bow to the beasts' pressures of wealth, power, materialism, or false religion.

They sing a new song, a melody that only they can learn (Revelation 14:3). This symbolizes their joy and happiness in their unique relationship with God and their unwavering commitment in the face of persecution.

The world's kingdoms may follow power and wealth through deception, but the followers of the Lamb belong to a different Kingdom, one not built on force or greed but on faithfulness, humility, and selfless love. Just as Babylon/Rome seeks to control through political and economic dominance, these 144,000 stand as witnesses to a different way—the way of the Lamb, marked by justice, mercy, and sacrificial love. Their song is not just a melody but an anthem of allegiance, a testimony that they have chosen faithfulness over compromise, Christ over empire, and the Kingdom of God over the kingdoms of this world.

The Two Harvests

John then sees two harvests (Revelation 14:14-20), which echo Joseph's dream in Genesis 40-41. In Genesis, Pharaoh dreams of seven healthy ears of grain, followed by seven withered ears. Joseph interprets these as a coming harvest and a coming famine, symbolizing a time of blessing and a time of judgment—similar to the separation between the grain harvest (God's faithful) and the grape harvest (the wicked) in Revelation 14:

1. **A grain harvest**, where the Son of Man gathers His faithful people.
2. **A grape harvest**, where the wicked are gathered and thrown into the winepress to be crushed.

This echoes Isaiah 63:2-3, where God tramples the nations like grapes, bringing justice against evil. The imagery of blood flowing from the winepress is not about God's cruelty but about the end of oppressive systems that have crushed the faithful and innocent for centuries.

The Seven Bowls of Wrath: Echoes of the Exodus

John's vision then shifts to the final cycle of judgments—the seven bowls of wrath (Revelation 15-16). These judgments parallel the plagues of Egypt, emphasizing that just as God judged Pharaoh and freed Israel, so too will He judge Babylon and free His people. These parallels include:

- **Painful sores** (Revelation 16:2) — Echoes the **boils of Egypt** (Exodus 9:8-12).
- **Sea and river turning to blood** (Revelation 16:3-4) — Mirrors **the Nile turning to blood** (Exodus 7:17-21).
- **Darkness** (Revelation 16:10) — Echoes **the plague of darkness** (Exodus 10:21-23).
- **A great earthquake and hail** (Revelation 16:18-21) — Represents **the Plague of Hail** (Exodus 9:13-35).
- **Unclean spirits like frogs** (Revelation 16:13-14) — Echoes the **Plague of Frogs** (Exodus 8:1-15).
- And the **death of all life in the sea** (Revelation 16:3) — Mirrors the **death of fish in the Nile** (Exodus 7:18, 21).

Why did God unleash His wrath on Egypt? To free the captives and liberate the oppressed (Exodus 3:7-12). This has always been God's heart—and, according to the Hebrew prophets, a central part of the Messiah's mission:

> *The Spirit of the Lord God is upon me; because the Lord hath anointed me to preach good tidings unto the meek; he hath sent me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to them that are bound; To proclaim the acceptable year of the Lord, and the day of vengeance of our God; to comfort all*

that mourn; To appoint unto them that mourn in Zion, to give unto them beauty for ashes, the oil of joy for mourning, the garment of praise for the spirit of heaviness; that they might be called trees of righteousness, the planting of the Lord, that he might be glorified.

Isaiah 61:1-3

And, of course, according to Jesus Himself:

As was his custom, he went to the synagogue on the Sabbath day, and he stood up to read. And the scroll of the prophet Isaiah was given to him. He unrolled the scroll and found the place where it was written: "The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty those who are oppressed, to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor." And he rolled up the scroll and gave it back to the attendant and sat down.

Luke 4:16-20

Thus, it should come as no surprise that Revelation echoes this very same message—God's judgment is not about arbitrary wrath but about delivering the oppressed and bringing justice.

Armageddon: A Symbol of the Battle Between Good and Evil

Armageddon (Hebrew: *Har Megiddo*, meaning "Hill of Megiddo") carries significant symbolic weight in Judaism and the Old Testament. Megiddo was an important battlefield in ancient Israel where many decisive conflicts took place (Judges 5:19; 2 Kings 23:29). It became a symbol of cosmic struggle, divine judgment, and the clash between good and evil. In Jewish thought, Megiddo became a symbol of God's final

judgment and ultimate justice, much like the prophecies of Ezekiel 38-39 (Gog and Magog) and Zechariah 14.

Thus, John's use of "Armageddon" in Revelation 16:16 is not about a literal geographical battlefield location but a known symbolic image of the ultimate confrontation between God's kingdom and the forces of evil.

John is painting a stunning theological picture—Armageddon is not a physical war with troops, fighter jets, and tanks, but a cosmic battle between truth and deception, righteousness and wickedness, love and oppression. Jesus never fought like earthly kings because His victory was secured through the cross. Those who continue to resist His justice will face the natural consequences of their choices—destruction—because evil ultimately collapses in on itself.

Conclusion: The Choice Between the Beast and the Lamb

Revelation 13-16 presents two competing kingdoms:

- **The beastly empires** of the world, built on violence, greed, and deception.
- **The Kingdom of the Lamb**, built on love, mercy, sacrifice, faithfulness, and justice. [28]

Every person must choose which kingdom to follow. Will we pledge allegiance to the beast, following power and wealth? Or will we follow the Lamb, even if it means suffering?

Revelation 17-20: The Fall of Babylon

Now that John has fully unpacked the message of the Lamb's unsealed scroll — God's cosmic plan to judge and redeem through the victory of the Lamb — he expands upon three key themes introduced earlier: (1) The fall of "Babylon." (2) The defeat of evil. (3) The coming of His Kingdom (the New Jerusalem). Each one explores the same concept — the ultimate coming of God's Kingdom — from a different angle.

The Fall of Babylon: The Prostitute on the Beast

John is shown a stunning woman, dressed in luxury, yet intoxicated with the blood of the martyrs and the innocent (Revelation 17:3-6). This woman is called *Babylon the Great, the Mother of Prostitutes,* and she is riding on a scarlet beast. Scarlet symbolizes luxury, sin, and bloodshed (e.g., Proverbs 31:21, Isaiah 1:18, Luke 16:19) — fitting for a corrupt, powerful figure like Babylon, who is both seductive and violent.

Thus, the "scarlet beast" is the same beast — the first beast — that represents oppressive worldly empires. Babylon is not merely a city or a woman — it is a symbol of corrupt power, one that arises repeatedly in history, enslaving nations and persecuting the righteous.

To John's first-century audience in specific, Babylon was an obvious reference to Rome, the empire that oppressed Christians and promoted emperor worship. However, Babylon is more than just Rome; it represents any world power that exalts itself and sees itself equal or above God, using military, economic, and religious influence to deceive. This vision borrows heavily from Old Testament imagery

describing the downfall of other great empires, including Babylon, Tyre, and Edom (e.g., Isaiah 13; 23; 34; 47; Jeremiah 50-51; Ezekiel 26-27).

Babylon is depicted as a prostitute, symbolizing a civilization that sells its moral values for wealth and power, seducing rulers and nations with luxury, intimidate with violence and oppression, and eventually brings to idolatry. But John makes it clear — this system will not last forever. In Revelation 18, Babylon's downfall is described in vivid poetic language:

> *Fallen, fallen is Babylon the Great!... In one hour your doom has come!*
>
> Revelation 18:2, 10

By the time of John, the Babylonian Empire had long ceased to exist, yet it remained a metaphor — serving as the prototype for all oppressive empires.

While some Protestants have speculated that Babylon refers to the Catholic Church, this interpretation is historically and contextually weak. Instead, the imagery applies to empires that oppress the innocent, worships wealth and power, and stand in opposition to God's justice. It was Rome in John's day, but it has been repeated in many forms since then, often infused by religion (the second beast). Nations and empires that exalt their own power always fall, and Babylon's demise serves as a warning to all who put their faith in worldly power rather than in God.

Babylon fell, Persia fell, Rome fell, Byzantium fell, and every empire since has eventually crumbled — none proved eternal. Jesus's Kingdom, however, will last forever!

The Last Battle: Jesus on a White Horse

At the turning point of Revelation's story, John sees Jesus returning — not as a baby in a manger, but as a conquering King (Revelation 19:11-16). He rides a white horse, a symbol of victory, and is called "Faithful" and "True." As mentioned previously, white horses in ancient times represented victory and success, particularly used by

victorious generals or kings. Jesus rides a white horse to signal His return as a righteous, victorious King, not just a warrior.

Nevertheless, Christ does not return with fighter jets, tanks, and missiles. His only weapon is *"the sword of His mouth"* (Revelation 19:15), a symbol of His teaching, authority, and truth. Rather than physical violence, it represents Jesus' authority to judge, expose falsehood, and bring justice through His spoken truth (Isaiah 11:4; Hebrews 4:12).

But there's another striking detail — before the battle even begins, His robe is already covered in blood (Revelation 19:13). How is that possible? Whose blood is it? It is His own. This is a crucial reversal of expectations. In most apocalyptic battle scenes, the warrior's robe is stained *after* the fight — with the blood of his enemy. But here, Jesus enters the battle already covered in blood — the blood of His sacrifice on the cross. This is a reminder that He does not conquer through violence, but through self-sacrifice — His blood.

Some modern Western gospel presentations depict Jesus's blood as a symbol of God's wrath being appeased. However, that was never the original intent. Before Christianity took shape, His Jewish followers understood His blood as a symbol of self-sacrifice. They were, after all, Jews. And much like Israel's sacrificial system, the role of blood was not to satisfy wrath, but to cleanse the altar, purify the priests, and sanctify the Holy of Holies.

If the Old Covenant's sacrifices cleansed, purified, and sanctified the people of Israel, then Jesus's sacrifice — the ultimate sacrifice — cleansed, purified, and sanctified the world (Hebrews 9:13–14, 10:10-14) This is also something John himself taught (John 1:29, 1 John 2:2).

I invite you to explore this topic further in my book, ***The Gospel Before Christianity: A Jewish Perspective on Jesus' Atonement, Sacrifice, and Redemption.***

The False Prophet = The Second Beast

Revelation 19:20 describes the defeat of the two beasts, also mentioning that the False Prophet (the second beast) used its power to perform signs on behalf of the first beast.

A false prophet, according to the Torah, is anyone or any doctrine that claims to speak for God but leads people away from Him (Deuteronomy 13:1-5). This is the essence of taking God's name in vain — using God's authority to promote falsehood, injustice, deception, idolatry, or personal gain. It is Satan's ultimate deception!

In Revelation, the False Prophet (Revelation 16:13, 19:20) serves this exact role. It represents a religious ideology or force of deception that speaks in God's name, performs false signs and wonders, and leading people to worship the beast. Instead of pointing to the true God, it manipulates faith to serve corrupt political and economic systems, making it a tool of deception rather than a servant of truth.

It's crucial to note that the False Prophet — the Second Beast — doesn't lead people straight to the Dragon (Satan). Instead, it deceives them to worship the First Beast (corrupt worldly empires). This highlights a deceptive system of religion or ideology that masquerades as righteous or Christian-like while corrupting believers into oppressive, power-hungry, and beastly behavior. This captures Revelation's warning about the subtle dangers of religious deception that misuses Jesus' name for corrupt and worldly purposes.

Satan's tactic of misusing God's name isn't merely a onetime future event; it is an ongoing strategy of deception captured repeatedly throughout Scripture (e.g., Exodus 20:7; Jeremiah 23:25-27; Ezekiel 13:6-9). Jesus himself explicitly warned against such deceptive misuse of God's name (Matthew 7:15-23; 24:4-5, 24).

The Thousand-Year Reign: What Does It Mean?

After the defeat of the Beast and the False Prophet, John sees the faithful who were martyred reigning with Christ for a thousand years (Revelation 20:4-6). This "Millennium" has been one of the most debated passages in Revelation.[29]

The number 1,000 is highly symbolic in the Old Testament and Jewish thought. It often represents completeness, vastness, or divine perfection rather than a literal count. Here are a few significant examples:

God's covenantal faithfulness – *"He remembers His covenant forever, the word He commanded, for a **thousand generations**."* (Psalm 105:8) – This does not mean God's covenant lasts exactly 1,000 generations, but rather that His faithfulness is unbreakable and eternal.

A symbol of God's dominion over time – *"For a **thousand years** in Your sight are like a day that has just gone by."* (Psalm 90:4) – This is not a literal formula equating one day in heaven to a thousand years on earth, but a poetic expression emphasizing God's sovereignty over time. It illustrates that what feels like an eternity to humans is merely a fleeting moment in God's perspective, reinforcing His timeless rule and control over history.

Blessings and multiplication – *"May the Lord, the God of your ancestors, increase you a **thousand times** and bless you as He has promised!"* (Deuteronomy 1:11) – Again, not a literal limit, but an expression of abundance and divine generosity.

A thousand as the ultimate measure – *"One man of you shall chase a **thousand**, for the Lord your God is He who fights for you."* (Joshua 23:10) – This conveys God's power working through His people, not a precise battle tactic.

Thus, when Revelation 20 speaks of a 1,000-year reign, it is best understood within this context. It is not necessarily a fixed, literal duration but a symbol of God's ultimate, complete and decisive rule, where justice prevails and Christ's followers reign with Him. The exact length is secondary to the assurance that evil does not have the final word and that God's kingdom will fully come in His perfect timing.

If the 1,000 years symbolize a complete, undefined period rather than a literal time-span, then Satan's "return" is not about a single future event but a recurring pattern. It reflects how, throughout history, evil resurfaces after periods of peace, testing humanity again. The cycle of rebellion and judgment continues until God's final act of justice permanently removes evil from His creation.

Either way, whether the 1,000 are literal or symbolic, the key point remains: God's truth and justice will prevail. Evil does not have the final word.

At some point, Satan's final attempt will come. He will test humanity one last time, gathering the nations for a final rebellion (Revelation 20:7-10). In other words, he will once again deceive many — perhaps even the majority — before facing ultimate defeat. This battle, often called the Battle of Gog and Magog, echoes Ezekiel 38-39, where a coalition of enemies rises against God's people. However, just as in Ezekiel's vision, the rebellion is crushed instantly (*"In one hour your doom has come"*), using strong imagery of fire from heaven that consumes the wicked.

The Lake of Fire and Sulfur

The Lake of Fire and Sulfur (Revelation 20:15) is one of the most misinterpreted imagery in Scripture, often taken out of its biblical and historical context to fit later theological constructs while ignoring known apocalyptic imagery rooted in the Hebrew Bible and Second Temple Jewish thought. If you want a deeper exploration of this topic, I have written extensively about it in another book: ***HELL: A Jewish Perspective on a Christian Doctrine***.

But here is the gist of it…

Lake

The Greek term "limné," translated as "lake," can refer to a pond of any size, suggesting a small pool of molten metal akin to what one would find in a refiner's crucible rather than an expansive lake.

Fire

Despite Revelation being filled with symbolic imagery drawn from the Old Testament and Jewish apocalyptic literature, some approach this particular image as if it must refer to a literal cosmic furnace — without considering its biblical context, symbolic meaning, or how fire was understood in biblical times.

"Fire from heaven consuming the wicked" (Revelation 20:9) does not necessarily indicate their annihilation but rather their exposure and judgment. Since fire is often used in the Bible as a symbol of purification, refining judgment, and spiritual cleansing (e.g., Malachi 3:2-3; Zechariah 13:9; Isaiah 48:10; 1 Peter 1:7; 1 Corinthians 3:13-15; Hebrews 12:29; Revelation 3:18), this imagery suggests that God's justice will refine, expose, and cleanse all evil, rather than simply destroy for destruction's sake. In other words, God's fire does not exist to destroy but to consume the sin within

sinners. It is not a sadistic fire of an abuser, but of holy love — a purifying flame that burns away all that is unworthy of the divine image.

This aligns with the idea that divine judgment is not about arbitrary punishment but about bringing all things into the light, refining what can be redeemed, and purging what cannot be reconciled with God's Kingdom.

At last, all evil is brought before God's throne of justice to face its ultimate defeat. The forces of spiritual evil — the dragon, Babylon, and all who aligned with them — become completely powerless, unable to corrupt or threaten God's creation any longer. Evil's influence is extinguished, ensuring that God's Kingdom will never again be tainted by the darkness of rebellion.

Sulfur

In ancient times, the combination of fire and sulfur symbolized the gold refining process, essentially a crucible of molten gold with sulfur added to remove impurities. Sulfur, or brimstone, has been used in metal refining since ancient times. One significant use of sulfur in ancient metal refining involved its ability to convert unwanted metals into sulfides. These sulfides would then react and smoke, allowing the purer metals, such as gold, to settle at the bottom of the crucible. This method was effective in removing impurities from the metal, enhancing its purity and value.

This fact is also evident in biblical texts such as Revelation 3:18, where Christ advises, *"I counsel you to buy from me gold refined by fire,"* using the imagery of gold refined in fire while admonishing the church in Laodicea.

Thus, in ancient perceptions, fire and sulfur, though painful, were considered a beneficial process of purification, rather than the Middle Ages' view of them as literal tools of a sadistic, torturous punishment.

Torment

The word *"torment"* in scriptures is translated from the Greek *basanizó*, which originally referred to a touchstone — a black stone used to test the purity of precious metals. Thus, the term should be understood not as a torturous torment but as a (perhaps very unpleasant) process of testing purity and refinement.

Forever and Ever

The Greek phrase often translated as "forever and ever" is more accurately rendered "unto the ages of the ages," indicating a future period of undetermined time — rather than the modern philosophical concept of endless duration.

For instance, according to the Interpreter's Dictionary of the Bible:

> **Time:** The Old Testament and the New Testament are not acquainted with the conception of eternity as timelessness. The Old Testament has not developed a special term for "eternity." The word aion originally meant "vital force," "life," then "age," "lifetime." [30]

Likewise, the 19th-century theologian Charles Ellicott explains:

> I must be admitted that the Greek word which is rendered "eternal" does not, in itself, involve endlessness, but rather, duration, whether through an age or succession of ages, and that it is therefore applied in the New Testament to periods of time that have had both a beginning and ending. [31]

And, in James Hasting's Dictionary of the New Testament:

Eternity: There is no word either in the Old Testament Hebrew or the New Testament Greek to express the abstract idea of eternity.[32]

Again, I have written extensively about it in my book, ***HELL: A Jewish Perspective on a Christian Doctrine.*** The book received fantastic reviews, and I truly believe you should check it out!

The Great White Throne of Judgment: The End of Sin, Not Sinners

John then sees the dead standing before God's throne, where the books of deeds are opened (Revelation 20:11-15). This is the final judgment, where everyone is held accountable for their actions. The purpose of a just judgment is not merely punishment, but the removal of all that is opposed to God's goodness.

What is the Book of Life?

In the Hebrew Scriptures, the "Book of Life" or the "Book of the Living" lists those presently alive on the earth, whether righteous or wicked (Exod. 32:32-33; Deut. 29:20; Ps. 69:28; Isa. 4:3).

The Book of Life/Living is mentioned in the Bible in three ways:

1. **The Book of the Living:** Psalm 69:28.
2. **The Book of Life:** Philippians 4:3; Revelation 3:5; 20:12, 15.
3. **The Lamb's Book of Life:** Revelation 13:8; 21:27.

Whether discussing the Book of Life or the Lamb's Book of Life, the fundamental point remains that those whose names are written in these books are alive. Different interpretations exist about whether these are two separate books or one single book with varying functions. One interpretation suggests the Book of Life lists everyone

who is alive, while the Lamb's Book of Life lists those who will receive great honor. Another interpretation is that there is only one Book of Life.

In John's time, many towns, including Sardis, had citizenship rosters listing the names of their citizens. When a person died, their name was removed from the roster. Additionally, if a person committed severe crimes and brought great shame upon the town, they might also be removed from the roster.

The promise to never remove an overcomer's name from the Book of Life symbolizes a tribute of great honor and respect — even after they die! It indicates that those who faithfully served Him will receive special recognition in God's Kingdom to come.

Conclusion: The Triumph of the Lamb

Revelation 17-20 brings God's story to its dramatic conclusion—evil is defeated, the beastly powers collapse, justice is served, and Jesus reigns as King.

But this vision is not just about the future. John is reminding his readers that Babylon exists in every generation—in the form of corrupt governments, economic systems that exploit the poor, or religious institutions that seek power and authority instead of service and truth.

The hope of Revelation is that God will not let Babylons continue forever. His Kingdom is already here and it will eventually overcome all others — a kingdom not of violence and oppression, but of justice, mercy, and sacrificial love — the New Jerusalem.

Revelation is a call not just to wait for the end, but to resist Babylon today by living as citizens of God's Kingdom—a Kingdom where the Lamb reigns, and love conquers all. The choice is placed before every person in every age: Will we side with the beasts or with the Lamb?

Revelation 21-22: The New Heaven and Earth

At last, John's vision reaches its climax with the most breathtaking and hopeful scene in all of Scripture: the renewal of creation — a new heaven and a new earth.

John sees a holy city — the New Jerusalem — coming down from heaven (Revelation 21:2). This is not so much about a geographical location as much as it is about a symbol of God's dwelling with humanity. The story of the Bible began in a garden (Genesis 2), and will end with a city, demonstrating the fulfillment of God's command to fill the earth and subdue it (Genesis 1:28).

Thus, this is not just a return to Eden, but a step forward—a redeemed creation where God and humanity fully dwell together, fulfilling the divine purpose from the beginning.

The Grand Finale: A New Creation

Notice that in Revelation 21:2, the New Jerusalem doesn't whisk believers away to another realm, nor does it signal the earth's destruction. Instead, it comes down from heaven to the renewed earth — a vision of restoration, not escape. This affirms the biblical pattern: God comes to dwell with humanity, not the other way around:

> *I saw the Holy City, the new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride beautifully dressed for her husband.*
>
> Revelation 21:2

This challenges a common misconception whereas the present earth is destroyed and discarded. Instead, Revelation presents a vision where heaven and earth are reunited, fulfilling God's original purpose of dwelling with humanity on earth, not removing us from it. This is the ultimate fulfillment of God's promises, a total renewal of creation, where all suffering, evil, and death are finally defeated.

John is not inventing something new here. His imagery is deeply rooted in Old Testament prophecy, particularly in Isaiah 65:17, where God declares:

> *See, I will create new heavens and a new earth. The former things will not be remembered, nor will they come to mind.*
>
> Isaiah 65:17

This is the final answer to the problem of evil — not an escape from reality, but its transformation. Just as Eden was a place of harmony between God and humanity on earth, so this New Jerusalem is a perfected Eden, but bigger and better (this time, no talking dragon!)

No More Pain, No More Death

Then, John hears a voice from the throne declaring the ultimate reversal of Genesis 2:17:

> *Look! God's dwelling place is now among the people, and He will dwell with them. They will be His people, and God Himself will be with them and be their God. He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away.*
>
> Revelation 21:3-4

This is one of the most powerful promises in the Bible, especially potent for those of us living in the Middle East, where death and grief are ever-present realities. Every form of suffering — every war, oppression, and tragedy — is undone, every disease is cured, and our greatest enemy—death—is defeated as all are resurrected back to life (Corinthians 15:21-22).

This echoes Isaiah 25:8, where God promises to *"wipe away the tears from all faces"* and to *"swallow up death forever."* This powerful connection shows the continuity between the hope of the Hebrew prophets and the vision of the Revelation.

"No More Pain, No More Death"—imagine that. Every wound healed, every sorrow lifted. All your bad memories, traumas, and regrets are gone—not erased from our memories, but redeemed!

The New Jerusalem isn't crafted from brand-new material; it's forged from the redeemed fragments of broken lives — a mosaic of mercy, resilience, and rebirth. It stands as a testament not to perfection, but to restoration. Perhaps it descends only when we, too, have learned to love our enemies and forgive those who sinned against us — not abstractly or theologically, but tangibly. In that moment of reconciliation, heaven touches earth, and the city of God is finally home among us.

If enemies will become friends, broken relationships will be restored, and love will reign where bitterness once lived, why not start mending relationships today? The true Christian hope is not just an escape from suffering; it is the ultimate renewal of all things: *"Behold, I make all things new."* (Revelation 21:5).

For the persecuted Christians in John's time, this was the ultimate hope. Many had watched loved ones be executed by Rome. Many had lost everything for their faith. But John reminds them: even death will not last. God will restore everything.

The New Jerusalem: A City Unlike Any Other

The New Jerusalem is not a gated community — it is a redeemed world, where humanity and God dwell together, fulfilling the original purpose of creation. *Salvation* in the Bible was often about restoring what is broken — from personal relationships to societies, from nature to nations — a reality where God's presence fills all things (Revelation 21:3-4). Thus, the problem of evil is not solved by causing more death but by manifesting heaven on earth — transforming and healing creation.

John's vision then zooms into the New Jerusalem (Revelation 21:10-21). It is massive, glowing with God's glory, and built with gold, jasper, sapphire, and other precious stones. These details are deeply rooted in the Old Testament, particularly in the Temple and the High Priest's breastplate, which reflect the imagery of the Garden of Eden and the role of Adam as a priestly figure.

The twelve foundation stones of the New Jerusalem mirror the twelve stones on the High Priest's breastplate (Exodus 28:15-21), each representing a tribe of Israel. This connection symbolizes the unity of God's people — both Israel and the nations — now fully redeemed. The materials used to describe the city also echo the Garden of Eden, which was rich with gold and precious stones (Genesis 2:12). Likewise, it mirrors Ezekiel's vision of the restored temple (Ezekiel 40-48), which is the renewed Garden of Eden — the New Jerusalem.

The city's gates are made of twelve pearls, and on them are written the names of the twelve apostles (Revelation 21:12-21). As both Jews and disciples of Christ, the twelve apostles represent both Israel and the Church, embodying the continuity between God's covenant, first with Israel, and then with the Church.

Why Is There No Temple?

I used to mingle in Christian groups where some members were completely fixated on—and absolutely obsessed with—the Third Temple, red heifers and blood moons. However, one of the most shocking statements in John's vision is that there is no temple in the New Jerusalem. This would have been a radical idea for John's audience, because the Temple in Jerusalem —no longer standing— was the central place of worship for Israel.

John figuratively describes the city as a perfect cube; 1,500 miles in every direction (Revelation 21:16). Why a cube? Because the Holy of Holies in the Temple was a cube (1 Kings 6:20). This means that the entire city — the New Jerusalem — is the new Holy of Holies. God's presence is no longer in a single room, but everywhere in the new creation (Revelation 21:22). The New Jerusalem is the fulfillment of everything the Temple symbolized—God dwelling among His people permanently, no longer limited to a building or a specific geographical location but encompassing all creation.

In other words, John doesn't suggest that a billion people will be squeezed into a 1,500-mile cube. Instead, he explains that God's presence is no longer confined to a temple — because now, God Himself is the temple.:

> *I did not see a temple in the city, because the Lord God Almighty and the Lamb are its temple.*
>
> Revelation 21:22

The entire city is now God's dwelling place. In the past, the Temple was where heaven and earth overlapped, but now, heaven and earth have fully merged — the whole world is sacred.

This ultimately accomplishes what Jesus mentioned to the Samaritan woman in John 4:21 — that worship (which refers to service and sacrifice for God, rather than musical performance[33]) would eventually transcend a specific place.

The River of Life and the Tree of Life

Echoing Old Testament imagery, Revelation 22:1-2 describes a river of life flowing from the throne of God. On both sides of the river grows the Tree of Life, which bears twelve kinds of fruit, and its leaves bring healing to the nations. This imagery is deeply rooted in Genesis and the Hebrew prophets, particularly Ezekiel's vision of the temple's river (Ezekiel 47:1-12).

In Ezekiel's prophecy, water flows from the temple, gradually growing into a mighty river that brings life wherever it goes, even turning the Dead Sea into fresh, living water — Creation itself is being restored (Romans 8:21). John takes this vision further — now, the entire city of God is the source of life, and all nations come and find healing and restoration.

The Tree of Life is a direct callback to Genesis 2:9, where God planted it in the Garden of Eden. It was meant to sustain eternal life, but humanity's sin barred them from it (Genesis 3:22-24). Now, in the New Jerusalem, the tree has returned—not

as a single tree but growing on both sides of the river, symbolizing abundance and restoration. What was once lost is now freely available to all.

This is more than just poetic imagery; it is a promise. The world we live in is filled with brokenness, pain, and division, but God's final vision is one of restoration, unity, and healing. Nations that once waged war will find peace, wounds and scars that once seemed unhealable will be mended, and the barriers that divided humanity will be torn down. The twelve fruits remind us of the twelve tribes of Israel and the twelve apostles, a symbol of God's complete and restored people.

The exile from Eden is over. Death is defeated. The world as we know it is transformed. The story of Scripture began in a garden, and now it ends in a garden-city.

We ate from the Tree of Knowledge, and knowledge we indeed received. But growing in knowledge is not merely about acquiring theoretical information — it comes through experience, struggle, and discovery. Ever since humanity was exiled from the Garden of Eden, we have been on a long, unending journey of learning — a history marked by pain and failure but also growth and redemption. Through this journey, we have come to understand something profound: God's love and why we should trust in His ways. And now, having truly learned what was once beyond our immature grasp, we are invited back to the Garden — not as naïve teenagers easily fooled by venomous talking dragons, but as those who have come to know God — His character, goodness and love — and freely choose to bow our knees before Him.

Come!

Then, John hears one final invitation

> *The Spirit and the Bride say, 'Come!' And let the one who hears say, 'Come!' Let the one who is thirsty come; and let the one who wishes take the free gift of the water of life.*
>
> Revelation 22:17

This is one of the most beautiful invitations in all of Scripture, echoing the great prophetic calls of the Old Testament (Isaiah 55:1). Don't wait — come now!

Ezekiel saw a river of life flowing from the Temple, bringing healing to all nations (Ezekiel 47:1-12), and Zechariah foresaw living waters flowing out of Jerusalem (Zechariah 14:8). Now, John sees the fulfillment of these ancient promises.

God's final message in Scripture is not condemnation, but invitation. The message of Revelation is not about a cosmic chaos, but about divine grace. Even at the very end, after all the warnings, judgments, and visions, God still calls out: *Come!*

This is a call to all who are weary, broken, searching, or longing for something more. It is an invitation to return — to the Garden, to the waters of life, to God's eternal love. The same God who walked with Adam and Eve in the cool of the day now welcomes all who will come and drink freely. The story of the Bible ends as it began: not with separation from God, but with communion with Him.

Conclusion

John's apocalypse does not focus on destruction, but on renewal. It's not a story of escape, but of restoration. The world does not end in fire but in a superb, renewed creation, where God's presence fills everything.

This is the grand conclusion of the entire biblical story:

- Genesis begins with a garden; Revelation ends with a perfected garden-city.
- Genesis tells of humanity's exile from God's presence; Revelation shows humanity living with God again.
- Genesis tells of pain and death entering the world; Revelation declares that pain and death are gone forever.

John's final vision was meant to fill the readers with hope, not distress. Their suffering and oppression are temporary. The struggles of the seven churches will pass away. In the end, God wins — not through military conquest and bloodshed, but through transformation, justice, and sacrificial love.

A Speculative Perspective on Future Events

Could Revelation — an apocalyptical piece written in symbolic language — also shed light on events still to come? The answer is yes — but not in the way many expect. Rather than offering a detailed, step-by-step prediction of world events, calendars and countdowns, Revelation reveals recurring patterns through symbols and cycles, including spiritual conflict, tribulations, judgment, and redemption that unfold throughout history — and will undoubtedly take on various forms in the future.

When exploring the central theme of a cosmic battle between good (the Lamb) and evil (the beasts) presented in the Book of Revelation and applying this theme to future developments, embracing the apocalyptic perspective becomes profoundly enriching. Unlike literal interpretations, an apocalyptic reading of Revelation considers future scenarios primarily through the symbolic and metaphorical language embedded in the text itself. This interpretative approach allows for open-mindedness, flexibility, and attentiveness to unfolding events rather than a fixation on a predetermined scenario that might obscure the real spiritual battle playing out before our eyes.

Let's have some fun experimenting a little with this idea — here is one thought-provoking scenario. Remember, this is speculative and intended to stimulate reflection rather than to predict specific events literally.

The Abomination of Desolation

"Abomination of desolation" (Daniel 9:27; Matthew 24:15) is a phrase from the Book

of Daniel that describes pagan influence or intrusion into the Jewish temple. For example, in the 2nd century BC, the Greek king Antiochus IV Epiphanes halted the twice-daily offerings in the temple and defiled it with pagan practices. By the 1st century AD, the phrase had turned into a Jewish idiom for foreign or pagan invasion of the temple.

During the lead-up to the Second Temple's destruction (especially between 66–70 AD), several events fit the description of the "abomination of desolation" in a first-century Jewish context, including the Zealot takeover (66 AD) and Roman standards in the Temple (70 AD). Further explanation can be found on my website.[34]

The main idea is that the temple was God's dwelling place on earth—the point where humanity encounters the Divine—precisely where evil would most want to enter and establish itself! But what if *"the abomination of desolation"* (Matthew 24:15) isn't limited to a historical statue placed within a stone temple, but instead symbolizes intrusive evil — an invasive attempt to establish its presence on the most sacred part of the throne of God?

Since the *Temple* is no longer a physical structure in Jerusalem but the individual believer, as Paul affirms (*"you are God's temple,"* 1 Corinthians 3:16), then the *Holy of Holies* within us must be our mind and will — the most sacred place within our temple-bodies. Thus, the "abomination of desolation" may be far more significant than merely an external statue of stone; it symbolizes something internal.

In other words, what if the Holy of Holies isn't geographic, but neurological?

Remember, Revelation describes a hostile conflict between those who pledge allegiance to God and those who pledge allegiance to the beast. Each group is symbolically marked on the forehead (Revelation 7:3; 13:16), representing the domain of the mind.

Let's explore this further...

1. The Mind/Will as the Holy of Holies

C.S. Lewis insightfully identified the human will as the ultimate seat of sovereignty within an individual.[35] The will resides deeper than emotion, deeper even than reason — it is the core place in our mind where we ultimately say "yes" or "no." Its sanctity lies in its freedom; its freedom flows directly from its sanctity — our minds![36]

2. The Neural Throne Invasion

Neuralink Corp. is an American neurotechnology company that, as of 2025, has developed an artificial intelligent based implantable brain–computer interfaces. Neuralink's technology enables paralyzed individuals to move objects with their minds through chips implanted directly into their brains.[37] And in March of 2025, the CL1 computer was introduced — the first in the world that combines human neurons with a silicon chip.[38]

When a technological AI-based implant can not only read signals from your brain but also send signals back into it — actively "writing code" into your neurological pathways — you are no longer the sole sovereign on the throne of your decisions.

In such a scenario, something external positions itself within the person's Holy of Holies—the human mind. Our will.

Since "God's temple" is no longer a physical stone building but the individual believer, then the "abomination of desolation" becomes internal — a digital and neurological usurpation of personal sovereignty. It becomes a code-level invasion of your very will.

3. The Abomination as Data Insertion

Genesis 3 introduces Satan's effort to entice and persuade humanity to follow his will instead of God's. Consider that the future's ultimate demonic attempt to seduce and control the human mind would not require a physical temple made of stone to manifest visibly. Instead, it needs only to implant itself as an idea or thought — or worse, directly control the human mind.

That represents true desolation: when human free will is no longer truly free. Free to love, repent, believe, or reject. This desecration is deeply spiritual — it's the tearing of the veil from the wrong side, allowing an entity other than God to occupy what is most sacred: the will of men.

4. Prophetic Implications and Modern Application

Perhaps scriptures envision a future scenario where a global system — represented by the Beast — would seize control of humanity's collective consciousness, overpowering individual freedom of choice and thought.

This would not merely be physical destruction; it would constitute spiritual devastation.

First, a Neuralink-like system might offer profound conveniences: enabling the mute to speak, the deaf to hear, the paralyzed to walk, and providing the average person with the perfect night's sleep and complete control over their dreams. By day, it offers enhanced cognition and mood regulation. It enhances life in such significant ways you can no longer imagine life without it. Trust is built incrementally until, eventually, the ultimate advancement emerges — promising immortality by uploading your entire consciousness into artificial intelligence, thus offering "eternal life" for those willing to surrender their will to the beast that promises godhood without God.

People may willingly embrace this neural invasion as convenience, technological progress, or human evolution, completely surrendering their autonomy without resistance, rebuilding the temple, not with stones, but with circuits. And when the abomination stood within it, it did not roar — it whispered. And people, valuing quantity over quality, comfort over freedom, gladly handed over the throne.

This isn't science fiction. AI scientist Ray Kurzweil has publicly predicted that by 2045, humans will fully merge with AI, transcending biology to achieve digital immortality.[39] He envisions a future where we'll be software, not hardware — a world where the mind can be backed up, restored, and transmitted across galaxies. In this vision, death is no longer the end — the mind won't die; it will upload.

Today, millions believe, and myriads follow him in the creation of a new "AI religion" promising a solution to mortality. Remember the second beast that poses as a lamb? The Lamb offers eternal life, and so will one day the beast.

Who Will Control It?

At some point, the most crucial question arises: Who's behind it?

It might present itself as entirely virtuous and benevolent, and maybe so it begins, but what happens if it falls into the wrong hands? Who or what controls this system, and thus, who controls your mind?

This eerily mirrors Paul's prophetic warning: *"He sets himself up in God's temple, proclaiming himself to be God."* (2 Thessalonians 2:4)

To surrender control of your mind is to surrender your will. And surrendering full control of the will is acceptable only if the controller is truly benevolent. But as Jesus reminds us, *"Only God is good."* (Mark 10:18).

Maybe I'm over-speculating — and maybe I sense what direction the wind blows. Either way, the point stands: ever since Genesis, there's always a battle for your mind, your thoughts, and your loyalty. Whether through a futuristic neural implant in your brain or the more subtle yet pervasive influence of so-called "free" media — mainstream outlets or social platforms — the threat of manipulation, mind control, and the engineering of our collective consciousness remains just as real, and just as dangerous.

> *Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind, that by testing you may discern what is the will of God, what is good and acceptable and perfect.*
>
> Romans 12:2

May we remain vigilant, spiritually alert, and profoundly discerning as we face the future.

If you are interested in exploring this futuristic technology-turned-divine scenario further, I strongly suggest checking out my wife's new short book, ***"God of AI: The Deification of Artificial Intelligence and the Rise of a New Technomancy Religion"*** by Anastasia Bar.

Conclusion: The Lamb Wins — So Choose Your Side

The Book of Revelation is not a riddle, a cryptic code, or a celestial timetable meant to decode tomorrow's headlines. It is a sweeping, symbolic vision — a sacred call to every generation to see the world as it truly is: a battleground of loyalties, where faithfulness to the Lamb is the only path through the chaos. Revelation doesn't give a detailed calendar of the end (making it irrelevant for most generations); it gives us something far more vital — a perspective, a sense of purpose, and hope that is applicable to all readers, not just a single concluding generation.

At its heart, Revelation unveils the cosmic struggle between good and evil and the pattern of human biography — the rise and fall of evil empires, the corrupting seduction of power, the oppression of the vulnerable, and the spiritual deception that fuels it all. But it also reveals this: evil never has the final word. Babylon may intoxicate the nations for a time, the Beast may roar, and the Dragon may rage — but the Lamb has already triumphed, and His people will reign with Him in the renewal of all things.

In some sense, Revelation is a book about politics — but not from the left or right. It's politics as seen from heaven's throne, where power is redefined not through domination, but through self-giving love. It unmasks the spiritual realities behind the world's systems and calls us to choose: will we pledge our allegiance to the beasts and dragon, driven by fear, greed, and coercion — or to the slain Lamb, whose weapon is truth and whose throne is a cross?

This is John's message to the churches of Asia — and to us today: stay faithful. Don't compromise. Don't bow to Babylon. Resist not with violence, but with truth. Overcome not with might, but with love. The early Christians were tempted to blend

in, to take the easy path of cultural conformity. So are we. But in Revelation, there is no neutral ground. Every decision is a declaration. Every compromise is a confession. Every silence speaks.

You may think you can sit this one out — but you can't. The battle is not coming — it's already here. The spirit of Babylon is alive in materialism, consumerism, imperialism, racism, violence, apathy, and empty religion. Following Jesus is not merely intellectually believing in Him; to be His disciple is to walk His path of sacrificial love, reject Babylon in all its forms, and live as though the kingdom of heaven is truly at hand.

Following the Beast is easy. It asks nothing but your indifference. But following the Lamb? That takes everything. It means loving your enemies when the world says hate. It means forgiving when bitterness feels righteous. It means staying true when compromise would be more comfortable.

But take heart — the Lamb wins. Babylon collapses. The Dragon is cast down. And those who stand with Jesus — wounded, weary, but faithful — will be clothed in white, crowned with glory, and welcomed into the New Jerusalem with great honor, where there are no more tears, no more death, and no more darkness.

Until then, let us remember — Christianity was never meant to blend in — it was meant to stand out. It was born to be a persecuted faith, a movement that thrives in contrast. Light is only seen clearly against darkness. Without opposition, without cost, the gospel loses its sharp edge. The early Church understood this: it wasn't comfort that revealed Christ to the world — it was courage. It was love in the face of hate. It was sacrifice in the face of misused power.

And that, dear reader, is my Jewish perspective on the Book of Revelation. It is not a message of fear, but of fierce and radiant hope. A call to wake up. A call to stand firm. A call to live now as citizens of the world to come. The kingdom is breaking in — and you have a part to play.

So lift your eyes, take up your cross, and follow the Lamb — through the storm, toward the dawn.

Lastly, to those who fear persecution, I say this: I've been there. I know. Don't let anxiety or bitterness consume you or poison your soul. Worry is a thief — stealing the joy of the present and distracting you from what truly matters. Invest in what lasts: your heart, your family, your loved ones, the poor, the outcast, and the needy. In the

end, you won't be judged by how you died, but by how you loved — how you treated others when it wasn't easy. That's the real test.

A Small Request

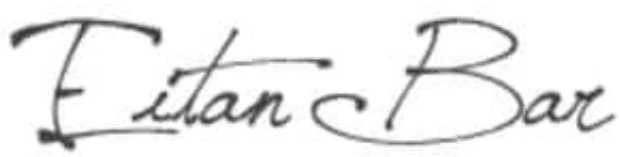
We may not agree on every little detail — and that is fine — but I hope you found my "Jewish perspective" convincing, or at least informative and uplifting. Before you close this book (or switch off your e-reader), I have a small yet important favor to ask. I have invested a considerable amount of time and effort into writing this book (and as a native Hebrew speaker, I accomplished this in a language that is not my own). Therefore, if this book blessed you in any way, please consider expressing your appreciation by sparing a few seconds to rate it on Amazon and Goodreads. If you also have two minutes to spare, leaving a short review would also mean the world to me. As an indie-author, I make it a point to read each and every review.

If you want to go the extra mile, feel free to post about the book on social media or even get copies for friends!

Finally, there are additional books covering a range of spiritual and biblical subjects that you can find on my Amazon page. Furthermore, you can explore a few hundred articles on my website, www.eitan.bar. I invite you to take a look at both!

Blessings from Israel,

Dr. Eitan Bar



1. e.g., Mishnah, Avot 5:21
2. Yeshua, which is the Hebrew name for Jesus, translates to "salvation."
3. Many Christians, especially Fundamentalists, misinterpret Jesus' atonement as a divine death penalty by a wrathful God because they've never studied how Old Testament sacrifices and atonement actually functioned—systems Jesus explicitly came to fulfill, not contradict. If you would like to learn more, consider my book, ***"The Gospel Before Christianity: A Jewish Perspective on Jesus' Atonement, Sacrifice, and Redemption."***
4. Messianic Judaism is a Protestant Fundamentalist movement that originated in the 19th century, primarily consisting of non-Jews. Currently, it is a diverse mix of predominantly Calvinists, Pentecostals, and Baptists who hold dispensational beliefs and observe Rabbinic traditions to some degree. For more information about Messianic Judaism see my book *"Why Don't Jews Believe in Jesus: A Jewish-Christian Unfolds the Great Mystery."*
5. "Sexual immorality" in Acts 15:29 was likely tied to idolatry, as pagan worship often involved temple prostitution and illicit sexual practices.
6. Tom Wallace, *Revelation – Introduction*, March 14, 2020.
7. *"Read Like a Jew: 8 Rules of Basic Bible Interpretation for the Christian"*. Available on Amazon.
8. Hence, the name of my book.
9. With over 15 million visits a year, according to their own reports.
10. Tim LaHaye, Revelation Unveiled, Zondervan Publishing House, Grand Rapids, 1999, p 17.
11. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xOAuXGFqEts
12. https://www.mercyuponall.org/2014/02/03/church-fathers-on-universal-salvation

13. E.g., Revelation 1:16; 2:16; 6:4; 6:9; 12:7; 13:3; 13:7; 13:10; 16:14; 19:14; 19:15; 19:19.
14. The original Greek word βιβλίον (*biblion*) could refer to either book or scroll, though in John's time, important writings were typically recorded on rolled parchments (scrolls) rather than bound books, which became common later. However, both "book" and "scroll" are practically the same.
15. For instance, the flood (Gen 6–9) preserved Noah to restart humanity; Babel's scattering (Gen 11:1–9) led to the eventual blessing of all nations (Gen 12:1–3); the plagues and Red Sea crossing judged Egypt but liberated Israel (Exod 6:6–7; 12:51); exile disciplined Judah yet promised restoration (Jer 29:10–14; Ezek 36:24–28); and at the cross, God judged sin to bring salvation (Isa 53:5; Rom 3:24–26; 5:8–9).
16. For a detailed examination of Hades, please refer to my book "*Hell: A Jewish Perspective on a Christian Doctrine*."
17. opendoorsus.org/en-US/stories/70-christians-murdered-in-drc
18. bronx.com/over-340-christians-massacred-in-syria-in-less-than-24-hours
19. Further information in my book, "*Lost in Translation: 15 Hebrew Words to Transform Your Christian Faith*."

20. E.g., 1 Kings 17:1; Luke 4:25; James 5:17; Daniel 7:25; 9:27; 12:7; Revelation 11:3; 12:6; 13:6.

21. More on that in my book, ***"The Gospel Before Christianity: A Jewish Perspective on Jesus' Atonement, Sacrifice, and Redemption."***

22. Jürgen Roloff, *Revelation: A Continental Commentary*, p. 164.

23. E.g., Revelation 5:6–14, 6:1, 7:9-17, 12:11, 13:8, 14:1-5, 15:3, 17:14, 19:7-9.

24. To their credit, the Catholic Church eventually learned from that mistake and now largely operates independently of the state, despite being the largest Christian denomination in the world.

25. For instance, see: Noel Lenski (ed.), *The Cambridge Companion to the Age of Constantine* (Cambridge University Press, 2006), "Introduction".

26. Augustine of Hippo, in the 4th century, developed and imported Neo-platonic doctrines that later became popular in both the Catholic and, eventually, the Protestant Church—including Original Sin, infant baptism, eternal conscious torment (hellfire), predestination, and more.

27. In our Hebrew Bibles, what your English Bible labels as ***Genesis 12:3*** appears in our Hebrew Bible as ***Genesis L:C*** (but in Hebrew). 'L' (the 12th letter) representing the number 12 and 'C' (the 3rd letter) representing the number 3.

28. To get a clearer idea of what that means, consider my book, ***"The Kingdom of Yeshua: Christ's Timeless Wisdom to Revive Your Spiritual Life."***

29. For instance, some interpret it literally as a future period of Christ reigning on earth, while others see it as a symbolic depiction of His current reign with His people in Heaven.

30. The Interpreter's Dictionary of the Bible (vol. IV, p. 641-655)

31. Eliott, Commentary on the Whole Bible (Matt. 25:46)

32. Hasting's Dictionary of the New Testament (Vol. III, p. 369, see also Vol. I, p. 542, art. Christ and the Gospels).

33. Here's a short article on a topic you might find interesting:
www.eitan.bar/worship

34. For a bird's eye view commentary on Matthew 24 (including the "Abomination of desolation"), check out my short article:
www.eitan.bar/matthew24

35. See "The Abolition of Man" and notably in "Mere Christianity", particularly in Book III, Chapter 2, "The 'Cardinal Virtues'."

36. In the Hebrew Scriptures, the human mind is depicted as the heart (e.g., Genesis 6:5, Deuteronomy 8:5, Proverbs 23:7), where God's law is inscribed not on stone tablets, but directly onto our hearts (Jeremiah 31:33, Proverbs 23:26).

37. BBC, Lewington, McMahon & Gerken, *"The man with a mind-reading chip in his brain - thanks to Elon Musk."* March 23rd, 2025.

38. Skyler Ware, "World's first computer that combines human brain with silicon now available." LiveScience.com. May 3rd, 2025.

39. Darren Orf, "*A Scientist Says Humans Will Reach the Singularity Within 21 Years*," Aug 08, 2024. Popular Mechanics magazine.